Would You Fall in Love with Me Again?

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/62068408.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora & Catra & Finn | Adora/Catra Child (She-Ra), Adora & Light Hope (She-Ra)

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Additional Tags:
Inspired by EPIC: The Musical - Jorge Rivera-Herrans, Specifically the Ithaca Saga, Implied/Referenced Rape/Non-con, nothing happens though, It is discussed and it is in CH2 and CH3 only, Each Chapter is Based on a Song in the Album, Angst with a Happy Ending, Blood and Violence, Adora is Odyesseus, Catra is Penelope, Finn is Telemachus, Prime is Antinous, The Clones are the Rest of the Suitors, Beheading in CH3, Lots of violence and blood in CH3, unreliable narrators, Pural because there's like three different narrators, Implied Sexual Content, Reunions, Adora Needs a Hug (She-Ra)

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English

Series:
Part 1 of SPOP Ithaca Saga

Stats:
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Would You Fall in Love with Me Again?

by AuthorWithoutaName

Summary

Twenty years... Adora has been gone for twenty years and there's been no word of what happened to her. The last time Catra saw her was when she left for war alongside most of Eternia. If it wasn't for Finn, she would have joined her and fight by her side during the war...

It's been twenty years since Adora last stepped foot on Eternia. She left her home with 600 of her people under her command. She spent ten years at war and another ten desperately trying to return to her family. After years of fighting, years of loss, years of longing, she finally finds herself on the shores of her kingdom.

(Basically, an Ithaca Saga AU but with Adora and Catra! And Finn as Telemachus! TWs will be in the author's notes, so please be aware, it isn't anything that isn't said or implied in the actual musical though! Each chapter is based on a song in the Ithaca Saga, starting with "The Challenge" and ending with "Would You Fall in Love with Me". CH1 is in Catra's POV, CH2 is in Adora's POV, CH3 in Hordak's POV, and then CH4 and CH5 are in Adora's POV. Made it a series because I will eventually write and post a version of the last chapter but in Catra's POV instead of Adora's)

Notes

Alright! Time for the Ithaca Saga AU! I'm excited for this fic and hopefully I did this story justice! Now, for trigger warns!

CH2 and (maybe) CH3 will have some dialogue about rape. Nothing will happen though! It's just a section that's in the musical so it's going to be here as well. I am going to try and keep it tamer though. I'll probably just have Adora's mind go

blank with rage as soon as she hears Prime utter words that imply that. Like I said, nothing happens, Adora kills Prime and the clones before they can ever do that.

CH3 will be violent. Again, this is part of the musical. CH3 is based on the song "Odysseus".

CH1 will be in Catra's POV and then CH2-CH5 in Adora's.

Also, thank you to Lyssandia for beta-reading this!! I appreciate you and all of your kind words!! It means a lot to me! I definitely recommend checking out her fics sometime! In addition to being a great beta-reader, she's an amazing writer as well!

Also, if you like Epic and She-Ra, ResFlower has a couple of SPOP fics based on Epic that I recommend checking out as well!

More notes at the end!

See the end of the work for more notes

The Challenge

Chapter I: The Challenge

The sun was just beginning to peak over the horizon. The golden light of the early morning filtered into the room. Soft and gold. It was quiet inside the palace and it was calm; a nice welcome from the rambunctiousness of the previous night.

Somewhere, in the old estate of Eternia's missing king, were a hundred and eight suitors. All of them sleeping off another night of drunken foolishness. The palace, once an immaculate crown jewel of the island, had fallen into disarray in the twenty years since the departure of its king.

In a large bed, a bed carved lovingly and delicately into the trunk of a tree, someone shifted. A quilted comforter, bulky and heavy, engulfed them, protecting them from the slight chill of the early dawn. It hid them from the light of the fast approaching morning, protecting them for just a few minutes more from another long day.

An arm poked out of the quilted shelter. It reached out at the space nearby. Her hand felt around the mattress, sliding across the sheets, as if searching for something or perhaps *someone*. After a moment, she stopped. The space was empty. It has been for *twenty years* now.

A sigh, defeated and pained, came from under the comforter. She shuffled under the comforter a bit, until her head finally peaked out from under her cocoon. Her ears, long and pointed, twitched as the warmth from the comforter faded. It was a magicat. Sleepily, she glanced at the spot next to her. Her mismatched eyes, one blue and one gold, narrowed and their ears immediately flickered down. Her ears rested deep against their unruly mane, as she realized once again that she was *alone*.

The presence she felt during the night… The familiar hug and warmth she was so sure she felt… The bright and vibrant blue eyes that she could have sworn she saw… The kind and smiling face… The hair that was as bright as the sun…

Just a dream… She reminded herself disappointedly, as she forced herself up in a sitting position. She hugged her knees to her chest. Her mismatched eyes lingered on the empty space.

Waking up alone wasn't unusual for her. She had spent a little over twenty years waking up in a bed that now felt much too big. Even before these last twenty years, she would often awake to find herself alone.

It was different back then though, she reminded herself. The person who used to sleep beside her was at least somewhere where she could reach her back then. She was somewhere on the island. She was…

Safe.

Alive.

Now she wasn't sure where Adora was or what she was doing. She had no idea if Adora was safe... If she was *alive*...

Catra sat on her bed for a bit longer, still gazing longingly at the empty spot. Adora's familiar scent had long since vanished. Now the only reminders she had of her were pictures hanging on the walls, memories that sometimes played out in her dreams, and their child. A child who, although not blood related to either of them, seemed to have inherited many of Adora's traits.

Finn hadn't grown up around Adora. They weren't even a year old when Adora left, but somehow they seemed to carry on Adora's spirit. They even dyed their hair blonde in an attempt to feel closer to her. More *connected* to the parent they had only ever seen in a single portrait.

It was a shock for Catra when she first saw Finn's changed hair. They did it themselves one day, after spending several weeks staring up at the large family portrait in one of the hallways. Over the years, Finn had asked her a lot about Adora.

Where was she?

What was she doing?

Why did she leave?

When would she be back?

Catra tried to answer every question, even when Finn repeated them. It didn't matter how often they asked the questions either.

She tried to give honest answers. Adora was one of their parents. Finn deserved to know more about her… but as the years went on and no word of Adora's whereabouts came, Catra found the questions harder to answer and she soon began to dread them. She ignored them, opting instead to redirect Finn's questions, distract them. Finn, the quiet genius that they were though, caught on and soon those questions stopped… For a bit at least. Soon they were replaced by a new question. One that still had to do with Adora:

Who was she?

What was she like?

That question first came about ten years ago. It was before Finn changed their hair to look more like her, before they decided to take up swordsmanship as a way to feel connected to Adora.

It was unexpected, though perhaps it shouldn't have been. It made Catra think. Just how was she supposed to describe Adora? How could she sum up Adora's past, herself to Finn? She never thought she would have to. Adora should have been around. Adora should be here, right now. Adora shouldn't have left them.

Who was Adora?

Although she was a queen, although had many servants to take on the everyday tasks for her, she still sometimes decided to do the occasional mundane chore, if only to keep herself busy. It was a habit that Adora had as well, one Catra had poked fun at relentlessly years ago.

Catra had been washing off their plates from breakfast. She knew that her maids would try to scold her for it later, but it was only two plates… She didn't feel the need to call them and have them wash two measly plates. Adora would do the same thing on occasion anyway, so it's not like she would be the first royal to do housework.

"Mama," Finn chirped as they sat at the table, watching her.

"Yes, Finnie," Catra called back, not stopping as she rinsed off first her plate.

There was a beat of silence. Catra frowned. Usually, if Finn wanted to talk, they didn't hesitate. They would just ask whatever it was that was on their mind. She went to turn the water off when a small voice continued, "Who was she?"

Catra stopped. One hand was still reaching out to grab the faucet and turn it off.

"Who was… Who are you talking about?" Catra asked, confused.

"Mom… Just who was she? Like…" Catra heard the sound of a chair moving behind her. It scraped against the hardwood floor. She heard the soft footsteps of Finn as they left the table and walked closer. They stopped just a couple of feet behind her. Catra took a deep breath. *Adora*. Whenever Finn asked about Adora or talked about her, they referred to her as *Mom*.

Catra gripped the sink for a moment, trying to steady herself. It had been ages since Finn last asked about their other mother.

Ages since Catra last said the word that was always on the tip of tongue, at the forefront of her thoughts… *Adora*...

"What…" Finn's words trailed off again, they sounded so uncertain and so *small* all of a sudden, as if they were afraid to bring up the subject of their other parent. Something that they shouldn't have to be afraid of. Even if Finn didn't remember Adora, even if the last time Adora ever saw them was when they were a baby, just a few months old, Adora was still a part of Finn. And Finn was a part of Adora.

Catra steadied herself. She kept the unshed tears in check. She wouldn't cry in front of their child. She *couldn't*. It might make Finn think that bringing up Adora wasn't an okay thing to do. She couldn't have that. Finn deserved the chance to talk about their missing mom. She turned around to face Finn. They looked… hesitant. Their ears were laying flat against their maroon mane and their usual smile was nowhere to be seen.

Catra gave them a soft smile and closed the distance between them. She knelt down so that she was eye-level with them.

"Your mom…" She began to say. The word faded out though as a sense of sadness began to over take her. She glanced away from Finn for a moment, and her eyes came to rest on a picture hanging above the mantle. It was of her and Adora, back before they had Finn. They looked so young then.

Carefree.

Adora's smiling face and bright blue eyes were so full of life. She wasn't sure where those blue eyes were now. If they even held the same spark they once did. What if that smile wasn't as large now? What if it faltered? She had heard stories from the older residents of the island, the ones who had gone off to war before, or watched their friends and family go off to war.

Shortly after Adora and the others left, many of the older villagers had come to talk to her. They warned her that when Adora

returned, she might not be the same. War changed people. War could break even the kindest and purest person, turning them into a shell of their former selves. Catra had scoffed at that. They didn't know Adora, not really, not like she *knew* Adora. Nothing would ever break that woman, Catra was sure of that.

Her gaze returned to Finn. Their blue eyes, so filled with life and adventure, reminded Catra of Adora for a moment. It made her smile. A genuine smile.

"Your mom *is* one of the bravest, kindest people that ever lived," she finally said in earnest.

Even if it had been ten years since she last saw Adora, she refused to use past tense when talking about her. War took time. She knew that. They hadn't gotten any word of Adora being dead. They hadn't gotten any news of the war either. It wasn't great but it wasn't bad either. There was hope.

"You know…" Catra added, a tiny bit of pride in her voice now, "You're a lot like her."

Finn immediately brightened. Their ears came back up and a small smile formed.

"I am?" They asked, excitement bubbling in their small voice.

"You are," Catra replied with a warm smile, gently booping Finn's nose as she said it.

Twenty Years… There was not a single day that went by where those two words didn't cross her mind. It used to be a smaller number. *One day*... *One day, since I saw her*… Soon the day became a week. A week became a month. A month became a year and soon the years ticked on.

Ten years…

Fifteen years

Twenty years…

Twenty years since she last saw Adora. Twenty years since Adora held a tiny baby Finn in her arms. Twenty years since she had last stepped foot on their little island. Twenty years since Eternia last had a queen. Twenty years since she and Finn last had a moment of peace in their *own* home.

Now Adora's estate was filled with suitors. A hundred and eight of them. It shouldn't have been a surprise. Eventually, word would (and eventually *did*) get out that Eternia was missing one of its queens. *Someone* would eventually try to make a claim for the throne and the best way to do that was by marrying Catra. It frustrated Catra greatly. Adora wasn't dead. She was only off to war. She was off to protect Eternia. She knew that Adora would return as soon as she could.

At first, the suitors treated her and Finn with respect. They were trying to win her heart. Win the throne… She let their presence slide. She didn't want them around, but they hadn't done anything wrong… *yet*... And as was the custom of the world, *guests* couldn't be kicked out without cause.

Most of the Eternians seemed to love the suitors as well and it soon became a question of politics. Would the Eternians rise up and forcefully remove Catra from the throne should she decide to just banish them from the palace? And if *that* were to happen, how would the Eternians treat everyone close to Catra? What would they do to Finn? To Glimmer and Bow? It was easier to just allow the suitors to stay…

As time went on, and it became more and more apparent that she wasn't going to choose a replacement for Adora, they began to become *impatient*. They became *dangerous* too…

Still though… The suitors were smart. They kept their actions on the edge of acceptable behavior. But Catra knew that time was running out. Sooner or later, their patience would finally vanish

and when it did, she just hoped that they didn't kill Finn to make her pay.

She left her bed finally, going over to her closet. She put her robe on over her nightgown and walked over to the open window. The white silk curtains swayed gently with the morning breeze, moving back and forth from the frame, as if beckoning her to look out.

From their bedroom in the palace, Catra had a vast view of the island and more importantly the ocean. Once again, as she did every morning, every afternoon when she could retire to her room for a bit, every evening and every night before she went to bed, she stared out at the vast expanse of sea.

Somewhere… Adora was out there. Traveling. Maybe fighting… She *had* to be. The alternative…

Catra frowned at that thought. The thought that was constantly at the back of her mind…

No matter what… It was a bad situation.

Either Adora was out there. She was fighting her hardest to get back home, to return to her family…

Or she was dead. Her bones either rotting away on some far off island, or buried somewhere deep in the endless sea…

Twenty years…

Twenty years Catra *waited*. Twenty years she awoke in a cold bed, without Adora by her side. Twenty years, she raised a child alone. *Their* child. Twenty years Eternia had gone without its ruler. It wasn't just Catra's loss. And it wasn't *just* Finn's. As much as it felt like it was.

Catra sighed as she watched the ocean. The sun was still barely above the horizon. The sky was pink and beautiful. Usually Adora would be up by this time, training with her sword in the courtyard. Sometimes Bow would join her and the two of them would spar.

Catra would often watch them, smiling she heard the two of them trade sharp quips against each other…

Glimmer was lucky. Just before Adora and the others were to leave, Bow injured himself. He wasn't able to leave with them. He tried. Of course he tried, that's just who he was, but Adora forbade it. And so he was left on the island, alongside everyone else who was deemed "unfit" for war. Glimmer missed the cut for war because she had just given birth to her own child and was still recovering.

Catra's brow furrowed as she thought back to yesterday, her mismatched eyes were still set on the blue horizon. Yesterday afternoon, there was a storm. It never hit the island. It looked fierce though. The whole sky had turned black. Lightning flashed threateningly in the distance. Thunder rumbled… No… It *roared*. Despite not reaching their shores, it was a storm unlike any other she had seen before… except for…

There was *one* other time that she recalled seeing a storm like *that*. It was over ten years ago though and it was when some ships were spotted just off their shores. The ships were too far away from their island for anyone to tell who they belonged to. The storm came and then… There was nothing but destruction. The wreckage never made it to their beaches. But they assumed that there were no survivors.

The storm yesterday… It reminded her so *much* of the storm from that day. She had a strange feeling when it occurred. It felt like… some kind of sign… an *omen*. It gave her a feeling. A feeling that *everything* was about to change.

The storm, coupled with her dream last night… Maybe it was *time*. Time for a change. Time for her to deal with the suitors. Time for her to deal with the insistent groanings of Eternia as they whine about needing a new ruler. Time for Catra to buy Adora more time…

She took a step back from the window and glanced over at the shroud hanging on the weaving loom. It was half unfinished. Or rather… half *unmade*. She started weaving it about three years ago. Upset and tired of the constant demands for a new king, she told everyone that she would select a new king once it was done. Once it was completed, she would set up a challenge and whoever passed it, would become king and rule by her side.

It was a shroud for Adora. A *funeral* shroud. Although there was no body, and there was no real *proof* that Adora was dead, many believed that she was… And maybe over the years, Catra had begun to believe it as well… *Maybe*. It was certainly a thought that crossed her mind often enough…

Twenty years was a long time. So much could happen in that span. There was danger everywhere. Even if Adora survived the war, she still had the *ruthlessness* of the sea to contend with. She still had monsters to face on her journey home.

By weaving the shroud… By weaving the shroud, it gave her some *closure*... At least, it would in theory. She spent hours weaving. Every day she would retire to her bedroom and begin to work on the shroud. It was a testament to her memory of Adora… and every night, before bed… She would undo it. She would carefully undo every piece of string and threading there was, until it was just a ball of yarn once more.

Some of her servants had noticed and so over the last few months, she only undid part of it. She kept it halfway done, giving the illusion that she was still working on the shroud. Her plan worked. A little. She noticed the way some of her servants watched her, how they stared at her; their gazes were either disapproving or filled with concern for her mental and emotional state.

The shroud wasn't done. She hoped that she would never finish it truthfully. She had no real intention of finishing it. Still… She couldn't ignore the suitors. She couldn't ignore Eternia's demands for a new king… But maybe there was another solution.

She glanced once more at the open window. Her blue and gold eyes staring out at the open horizon. *Twenty years*… Twenty years and still… She would wait. Even if it took the rest of her life, she would spend it *waiting*…

Her resolve hardened. She almost stomped to her bedroom door and cracked it open. Four guards were posted outside her door. Two across from it, and two more beside it, one on each side. It was something Finn requested she do, after overhearing some of the things the suitors were saying in private. She gestured to one of the guards. They stepped a bit closer, still staying in the hall.

"Summon Glimmer and Bow. Tell them to meet me in the hall," she ordered sternly, and then she added, "It's time."

The guard's eyes went wide and they nodded. They almost sprinted down the hall, their hurried and heavy footsteps echoing through the halls.

She closed her door and turned so that her back was to it. She slumped against it and slid down to the floor, her ears once again pinned down against her mane. She buried her face in her hands as she replayed the words in her head.

It's time...

To everyone else, those words meant that it was time to move on. It meant that their remaining queen was *ready*... But she wasn't. She never would be.

The challenge...

A while back, she came up with the idea of a challenge. She *hoped* that it would appease both the suitors and the loud demands of Eternia for a new ruler. It showed that she *tried* to find them a new ruler, someone to help her lead their little island. It showed that she wasn't just *waiting*... She doubted that anyone could pass it. Not even her own child could complete the challenge. Not yet at least… Maybe one day Finn could, but that day wasn't today. Still though… There was a bit of fear in her. Fear

that maybe she was wrong. Fear that maybe, just maybe, there was someone among the suitors who could win the challenge…

No… She pushed that fear back. *Impossible…*

Not even Bow could complete this particular challenge and he was probably the second best warrior on the island… Maybe if Bow hadn't been injured… Maybe Adora would be back– No. There was no point in thinking of the millions of *what ifs*...

Catra took a deep breath. She finally looked up from her hands, her gaze now coming to rest on the second family portrait in their palace. It rested just above the fireplace in their bedroom. It wasn't the original. It was a repaint, done as a gift by a friend, Perfuma. It was just a copy of the original, to allow her to have a painting of her whole family in her bedroom. Adora was holding Finn. Her vibrant blue eyes soft as she gaze at the infant magicat in her arms. Catra was standing beside her, her head turned to stare at the little bundle in Adora's arms as well.

I haven't given up on you… She wanted to reach out. She longed to touch the painting, one of the last remaining artifacts of Adora's life. That she once *lived*...

I promise… I'm still waiting…

Catra rose shakily to her feet and went to get dressed. Today, she would have the suitors prove themselves. If they couldn't complete the challenge, then they and the island would wait. She spent twenty years waiting. Why couldn't they?

***

The hall was noisy. In addition to the suitors, it seemed as though half Eternia had appeared. The chattering was loud and just *a little* grating. There was excitement in the air.

Finn was standing beside Glimmer and Bow by the throne, looking frustrated. Catra didn't miss the way Finn's tail twitched irritatedly behind them, or the way their ears kept flickering back and forth, or the scowl on their face that only seemed to deepen once they laid their eyes on their mother.

Catra ignored it. She ignored the concerned expressions on Glimmer and Bow's faces as she walked across the stage, Adora's old bow in her hand. The suitors finally saw her. Someone in the crowd called her name. She didn't answer them though. Out of the corner of her eye, she saw the old, regal portrait of a much younger Adora. It was painted shortly after she was crowned. She was still a kid back then.

Catra stepped up to the throne. She stopped and then turned to face the crowd. All one hundred and eight suitors were standing, watching her. Interested. The worst of them, a man called Prime, watched her especially. She scanned the crowd. Most of the villagers who had long demanded a new king were in attendance as well.

Good.

If they were here, then they would see the challenge first hand and could report back to the rest of Eternia that she gave the suitors a fair shot. Hopefully this challenge would quiet the discourse that was running through the island. *Hopefully*…

For some reason, she caught sight of a stranger in the crowd.. Eternia didn't get many strangers now. *Weird*.

The stranger was dressed in a cloak that was much too large, it was worn and tattered as well, as if it had seen many travels, many storms, maybe battles. The hood was drawn up, hiding their face and head. For some reason, she felt *drawn* to the stranger. Like she somehow knew them. She couldn't see their eyes. She couldn't see the color of their hair. She saw nothing but the grey, tattered cloak, and the bottom half of their face. Still though…

There was *something* about that face. Even if she only saw half of it, it looked *familiar*.

Strange.

After the challenge, she would send Finn over to them to check on them. It wouldn't do to have a guest that wasn't taken care of after all. She glanced back at the crowd. She cleared her throat. The chatter died down and she spoke, as clear as she could and as loudly as she could without it being considered disrespectful:

"Whoever can string my wife's old bow and shoot through twelve axes *cleanly*..."

She nodded towards the twelve axes that were hanging on the wall in a space nearby. She watched as the crowd followed her gaze and heard a few stunned gasps as they studied the small hole that went through each ax. They were lined up perfectly.

"Whoever can complete this challenge… Will be the new king. And they will rule Eternia by my side," she finished, her tone serious and firm.

She felt the return of the crowds' stares on her, but her gaze was still on the axes. Her thoughts drifted back to Adora, to years long past. Soon an old phrase, one that Adora told her quite often when they were young, was on the tip of her tongue. And she began to repeat it. She thought it was stupid at first. She made fun of Adora throughout the years, using that *particular* phrase… Still, she repeated it, without the malicious or mirth that she would have used years ago:

"Let your arrow fly..."

The memory of Adora taking her to the countryside with the promise of teaching how to properly shoot a bow flashed in her head. She remembered watching Adora effortlessly stringing the bow. She recalled how *patient* Adora was, showing her just how to hold the bow, how to shoot the arrow. Before she let go of the

string that day, Adora whispered to her, "... once you know that your aim is true…"

Cause I would rather die than grow old without the best of you…

No matter what, Adora… I'll be here…

Waiting…

Waiting…

Waiting…

Hold Them Down

Chapter Summary

Adora returns to Eternia.

Chapter Notes

Alright, chapter two! Now this chapter does have the implied rape, but it's relatively minor. I put the tag on there to be safe. It's towards the end of the chapter and I marked the paragraph leading up to it with (***), so if you want to avoid it, you can. It's towards the end of the chapter. But if you've listened to the Ithaca Saga soundtrack, then it should be okay.

A special thanks to Lyssandia for beta-reading this!! Thank you so much! I appreciate you!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter II: Hold Them Down

"Whoever can string the old queen's bow and shoot through twelve axes cleanly…"

There was murmuring in the crowd. Catra's challenge was repeated among everyone. The suitors. The Eternians.

"...will be the new ruler…"

There was excitement now. The murmuring grew louder. The Eternians looked on with glee. Hope for a new ruler in their eyes.

"...sit down at the throne…"

The suitors' faces lit up at that statement. One of the suitors looked particularly *smug* at that part of Catra's speech.

"... and with Catra as *his* queen…"

One of the suitors whispered *that*. Only one… The words were spoken softly; they were said *just* under the suitor's breath; unnoticed, it seemed, to anyone... Anyone but Adora. She glanced in the man's direction. She carefully brought her hands up and tugged the hood down more, ensuring that her face wasn't visible to *anyone* as she looked at the man who said that…

He was tall. He towered over all the other suitors. Even the Eternians looked short when compared to him. His face was white, while his neck and hands were grey. His eyes were green and *calculating*. He was staring at Catra, studying her every move; every step she took on the stage.

Adora frowned. The way he said *it*…

And with Catra as his *queen…*

There was something about his words that made her skin crawl. There was something about his voice, about the way he *leered* at Catra… It unsettled her. She glanced at the other suitors. All of them seemed excited. Sure. They all had a chance to the throne… Or so they thought.

A small smirk tugged at her lips and she looked back up at the stage. Once again, she pulled at her hood. She had to keep herself hidden for now. Her gaze landed on Catra.
Her wife… And she sighed.
Twenty years…

The last time she saw Catra was twenty years ago. When she was standing on Eternia's shores, among the rest of the Eternians as they all saw her and her warriors off. She didn't want to leave. Catra definitely didn't want her to leave. They argued about it for weeks. As the day of her departure grew closer though, and it became apparent that she and Eternia were *needed* to turn the tide of the war…

Well…

The arguing stopped and it seemed as if Catra came to a quiet, though begrudging acceptance of Adora's impending departure.

She wasn't sure *how* Catra would react to seeing her again. Catra practically *pleaded* with her, *begging* her to let someone else take the reins, to take the responsibility of leading six hundred warriors out to war.

"You're the Queen, Adora! Just use your royal powers or whatever and have someone else do it!"

She had to look away. Her hands clenched into fists as she exhaled, exasperated. She knew Catra was scowling at her. She didn't even have to glance at her, she could picture it. Catra's tail must be twitching wildly now. It always did when she was angry.

They had had this argument for weeks. The morning was peaceful but soon after breakfast, someone had started up the conversation on when she was to leave. She couldn't even remember who asked her about the upcoming departure date, if it was Bow or one of her servants, or maybe even a guard in the palace.

No…

She thought about it some more. She doubted it was Bow that brought the topic up. He'd noticed Catra's irritation at the whole ordeal. And he was injured now too, unable to participate in the war. He wanted to. He didn't want her to go by herself… Well, she wasn't exactly by herself. She had six hundred of Eternia's warriors with her, but it wasn't enough for him. Or Glimmer. Or Catra.

The arguing began again. Glimmer came over and practically yanked Finn out of Adora's arms, demanding that the two of them take it up upstairs, promising to watch Finn as they discussed their current disagreement, as she put it. Bow was holding his and Glimmer's child, still sitting at the table, his crutch leaning against the table.

And so here they were. In their bedroom, Catra fuming and Adora feeling stuck. Stuck choosing between her duties as the First Queen of Eternia and her family. Stuck between her obligation as She-Ra, the hero chosen by Light Hope, and ensuring that she was around. Around for her wife and their child. But if she didn't go… If she decided to abandon her responsibilities as both the First Queen of Eternia and She-Ra, if she refused to accept her responsibility… Would it lead to the war eventually coming to Eternia?

She cared about her kingdom. She cared for her people. But she cared about her family more. If she could, she would trade the world for them. She didn't need the honor or the glory. She didn't set out to be She-Ra. She didn't set out to be a Queen of Eternia. It all happened by accident. She completed some trial Light Hope had set up. She didn't even know that's what it was. All she knew was that some strange monster had been terrorizing her neighbors and no one else seemed to be brave enough to face it.

Her feats that day bought her favor with her island. So, the Eternians made her queen and shortly after that, Light Hope came. She offered to mentor her and gifted her a magical sword. A sword that gave her the ability to become the greatest warrior.

She was only thirteen years old when all of that happened. Thirteen and ruler of a kingdom. Thirteen and suddenly being mentored by the greatest strategist in the world. She had no idea what was in store for her after that day. If she did, she probably wouldn't even attempt to find and kill that monster.

If things were different, if she wasn't She-Ra… Would she be allowed to stay home? Would Eternia even be asked to join the war efforts? She wondered for a moment if maybe her becoming Light Hope's pupil, if her becoming a Queen of Eternia, would end her.

She couldn't look at Catra right now. She didn't want to see the disappointment on her wife's face.

"Don't disappoint me."

That *was Light Hope's warning to her. Moments after she agreed to be Light Hope's pupil, just seconds after she accepted the sword… Don't disappoint me… She didn't want to disappoint her mentor, but right now, she felt as though she was disappointing Catra and she hated that thought more.*

But… She was doing this for Catra… Right? Light Hope said that they could make a greater tomorrow. The world needed change. There was so much wrong with it and maybe as She-Ra–

She exhaled again as the weight of her responsibilities fell on her. She-Ra was needed. If she didn't fight in the war over there, if she didn't stop the witch Shadow Weaver… There was no telling what could happen…

For years now, the Shadow Weaver had been a threat. She had en massed an army. She had conquered kingdoms. Her army had killed, They enslaved. She had basically created an empire; one that had been left unchecked for far too long.

If she didn't stop them now, would Shadow Weaver's army eventually come to their shores?

Would Eternia be safe?

What about Catra and Finn? How long could Adora ensure their safety?

So many had already fallen to the witch. Her army left nothing but destruction. Whole countries were gone now.

Kingdoms closer to the Shadow Weaver's empire asked for aid. They sent messengers to Eternia, demanding that Light Hope's chosen champion join the fray; that Eternia answer their call for aid.

Adora sighed. She unclenched her fists, forcing herself to relax a bit. Her shoulders loosened. She was still tense. Her heart felt

heavy at the thought of leaving her family behind. She finally ventured a glance at Catra. Her wife wasn't even looking at her now. Her arms were crossed, her ears pinned back against her mane, still messy and unruly from them only being up for about an hour now.

A small, sad smile touched Adora's lips. Just as she thought, Catra's tail was twitching wildly behind her. Her head was turned to the side and Adora turned her head to follow her gaze, to whatever it was Catra decided to focus her attention on. It was the window. The curtains were drawn back, giving them an uninterrupted view of the sea.

The curtains, white and silk, swayed gently with the breeze. It was coming from the sea, the wind, bringing with it the similar and strong, crisp and salty scent. The sea was active today. Even miles out, Adora could see small waves form and crash into each other. The sky was blue and there was barely a cloud.

Adora glanced again at Catra. She still wasn't looking at her. Her scowl seemed to have softened a bit at least… So, that was… something…

"Catra," she sighed. Catra's ear flickered in her direction. Adora took a step forward. A step towards her wife. She wanted to comfort her. Her hand moved up and began to reach out–

Don't disappoint me…

Light Hope's words echoed in her mind once more. She brought her hand down, letting it return limply to her side. Catra finally glanced at her then. The scowl was present. Adora sighed again.

"I have to do this, Catra," she whispered, her voice small and desperate. She took in another deep breath. She closed her eyes for a moment…

Inhale…

Exhale…

You're a warrior, Adora. Act like it!

She opened her eyes again and they met Catra's. She was staring at her, the scowl was gone now. Her ears weren't pinned against her mane, but her tail still flickered without ceasing. Her brows were furrowed now, her lips in a thin line… She was frowning, Adora realized. Actually, the more she looked at Catra, the more she realized that she looked more worried than angry now.

"I can't just–" Adora tried to explain. She tried to plead. She had to go. It was her responsibility. As Eternia's First Queen. As She-Ra. It was her duty. Her burden to bear. No one else could do it. She just had to explain that to Catra. Maybe if she did– But the words died in her throat. As soon as she began, Catra interrupted her.

"I know."

Adora stopped. Catra gave her a small but unconvincing smile. She walked over to Adora. Her tail stopped moving finally. She stopped just half a step away from Adora and reached out for her hand. She felt Catra's hand close around hers. Catra's tail moved as well and wrapped itself around her other wrist.

"Listen," Catra sighed and she closed her eyes for a moment. Silence lingered between them. She heard Catra sigh again, probably trying to gather her thoughts, probably trying to quell her temper that had been boiling over the last few days. Adora waited. After a bit, Catra opened her eyes again, her gaze meeting Adora's.

"I understand that."

"Catra–"

"No. Listen," Catra growled and she glared at Adora. Adora felt herself shrink under it, which Catra seemed to notice because then her expression and her tone softened again. She took a couple of deep breaths to steady herself and then continued, "I understand that you have to be She-Ra. I understand that you're

the Queen but I just–" She stopped and huffed in annoyance. She took another deep, calming breath. And then another.

"I just don't want to lose you… okay? I can't– And now we have Finn and– Finn deserves to have both of us, okay? I– I deserve–" Her words faltered, fading off into uncertainty.

Adora slowly and carefully took her hand out of Catra's. Catra's eyes widened in alarm at the gesture, but only for a moment, her expression then went to puzzled. Adora cupped Catra's face and brought their foreheads together.

"No matter what… I promise *that I'll return to you," she said earnestly.*

"You promise?" asked Catra, her voice now suddenly very small and there was a hint of doubt*. Adora's heart clenched at the tone. At how uncertain and hesitant Catra sounded. Catra doubted her, she realized. And Adora hated that.*

"I do," Adora replied firmly. She held Catra's gaze, trying to convey just how serious this promise was to her.

It must have worked… A small smile touched Catra's lips… It made Adora smile too… But only for a moment. The more her gaze lingered on Catra, the more her vibrate blue eyes, as blue as the sea (as Catra had once described them to her when they were young) stared deep into Catra's gold and blue eyes, the more she realized that the doubt hadn't left. It was still there. It lingered in Catra's mismatched eyes.

Adora hated it. She hated that her wife doubted her. That she was causing Catra such distress now. Maybe there was a good reason to doubt. Maybe–

"Then…" Catra's voice brought her out of the mental spiral she was about to go through.

"Then I promise to wait." Catra moved her head back, so that their foreheads were no longer touching. Adora frowned. Catra

took her hand back in hers and she continued, "Just know, I'll be waiting for you."

The memory began to fade. That day had repeated itself so many times in Adora's mind. In her dreams. In her waking moments, when the day got too quiet. Catra's words echoed in her head.

"…No matter how long it takes…"

Another promise repeated itself in her head. Another request. Catra saw how much pressure being the queen was. How much responsibility she felt due to her role as She-Ra, the hero chosen by Light Hope…

Before they left their room that day. Before they went back downstairs and got Finn from Glimmer and Bow, Catra stopped her. She had turned to walk away, her hand still in Catra's. But Catra didn't walk with her. Instead she continued to just stand, her hand still desperately clutching Adora's. Adora glanced at her worriedly.

"Whatever you do… Wherever you go… Just… Just don't change, Adora. Please…
Promise me that… Just… Continue to be… you…"

"I promise…"

She couldn't keep that promise. She had changed. And it wasn't for the best. It was for the worse actually. Everything Catra loved about her. It was gone. Gone was the kind and gentle woman Catra knew. Now, she was a monster. One who actually had traded the world away for just the chance of seeing her family.

Would Catra even love her anymore? And if not… Would Catra at least *fall in love* with her again? *Could she?*

Adora's breath hitched. Her chest ached. Her hands trembled. She blinked away some tears. She looked away. She couldn't bear to see them anymore. Maybe this was a mistake. Maybe they moved on… *Maybe–*

"Let your arrow fly…"

Catra's voice rang out. It pierced through the dark storm brewing in her mind. Adora's eyes widened.

Let your arrow fly…

She'd said those *very* words to Catra once. For a brief moment, she wasn't in the throne room. No. Adora was outside. The sky was blue, a few white clouds lazily drifting overhead. She had brought her bow and a quiver full of arrows. Catra was by her side. Her laugh drifted at the edges of her mind.

"...Once you know that your aim is true…"

She saw herself helping Catra draw the bow, helping her pull the string back. She heard herself whisper those words to Catra. She and Catra released the string, the arrow soared…

A small smile tugged at Adora's lips. This wasn't *just* a challenge. This was a *message*. A message to the suitors. A message to Eternia. Catra, Adora realized, wasn't ready. Twenty years and Catra was still *waiting*. Catra was waiting for *her*

For a moment… A *brief* moment, she allowed herself to hope. Maybe she would be accepted. Accepted by Catra at least… *Maybe*… The doubt still lingered and she realized that it probably would continue to do so until she got a chance to speak with Catra.

She stepped further back into the crowd of the Eternians. Her gaze wandered then to the twin thrones on the stage, where Bow and Glimmer were waiting… alongside a young magicat.

Finn…

It had to be them. She wasn't sure how she knew… But she did. The moment her eyes fell upon that magicat, she *knew*. They were older now. No longer that tiny infant that fit in her arms. She couldn't stop her breath from hitching. Her eyes filled with tears.

She tried to blink them back, but a couple of strays fell down her cheek. She angled her face away, trying to hide herself from view.

Twenty years… She'd missed her child's *whole* life. She took a couple of deep breaths. She tried to calm herself. She tried to take control of her breathing again. Her stomach twisted, her heart felt heavy again. But eventually, the tears stopped and her breathing slowed. She ventured another glance at Finn.

They looked… *different*. Their mane was blonde now… She could have sworn that it looked more like Catra's when she left. It wasn't just the hair though. Finn used to look *happy*. They had a smile that lit up the whole room. Now they were scowling. Scowling at the crowd. The suitors. *Catra*.

When did that happen? Adora wondered, and the guilt grew.

Finn looked absolutely displeased about the whole ordeal. Their tail was twitching irritatedly from side to side. Their ears were almost pinned back against their golden mane. Despite the pain she felt seeing her child looking so angry, she wanted to chuckle. The sight reminded her *so much* of Catra.

The challenge began. The suitors lined up, each to take a turn at stringing the old bow. Finn didn't stay. As soon as the challenge was announced, the suitors began to line up, Finn took off. Adora fought the urge to follow them. As if on instinct she had taken a step, but she stopped herself. She would meet with Finn soon. She would explain the situation. She would see *what* was going on with her child. But for right now… She turned, and glanced at the stage.

For now… Catra *needed* her. She could feel it.

The suitor from before, the one who leered at Catra was the first to try. She heard a few excited murmurs from the Eternians as he stepped onto the stage. A name was whispered in the crowd. *Prime*.

Prime wore a smug smirk as he walked up to Catra to take the bow from her. He tried to string it. He took *minutes* trying. His smirk soon dropped to a scowl. His frustration was plain on his face. Adora tried to not sneer at the man. She bit back a laugh as he eventually gave up with a growl.

She heard the shock murmur of the crowd as Prime gave up. One by one, the rest of the suitors marched up to Catra, all of them looking confident about their chances, despite seeing that Prime apparently couldn't do it. She kept glancing at Prime though, her gaze lingering on him. He was glaring at Catra, watching her with *hatred* in his eyes; a hatred Adora had seen before.

Adora's gaze hardened as she watched him. He was dangerous. She could feel it. Even without speaking with him, even though they had about half a room between each other, Adora could *feel* it. Prime would have to go.

It took hours. Hours for each suitor to attempt the challenge. Prime even demanded that he be allowed to try again after the last of the suitors went. And to Adora's disappointment, Catra *let* him.

She allowed him to step back up onto the stage. She handed the bow to him once again and she watched as he struggled to string it. After a few minutes, Catra asked for the bow back. To Adora's surprise, Prime handed it back to her...

Feeling as though the challenge was done, some of the Eternians in the crowd began to leave. Catra turned to leave as well, the bow in her hand. Before she could leave the stage though, Prime called out. His voice echoed harshly through the hall. It caused all of the Eternians to pause.

"Where is *she*?" he demanded.

Catra glanced back at Prime. For a moment, Adora wondered if she even heard what Prime asked. Her expression was blank.

"Where is the *one* who can string this bow?" Prime's voice boomed throughout the hall. His scowl deepened. The Eternians began to murmur.

Catra's blank expression turned to calmness. Glimmer took a step away from the throne, as if she was going to go to Catra's side. She held a hand up, stopping Glimmer immediately.

"You know… It's been *twenty years*, your majesty…" There was a sick *slickness* in how he said that title. He continued, "*Twenty years* and yet…" He paused, allowing the last word to hang in the air.
Adora glanced between Prime and Catra. Her fingers twitched. She wanted to reach back, to grab her sword, and *finish* these suitors now…

"And yet," Prime's voice was low. *Dangerous*. But Adora could still hear it clearly. And she was sure that all of the Eternians could as well.

"And yet, you still cling to the hope that your wife will return." Adora didn't miss the way Catra's eyes narrowed at Prime's words. "That your *Adora* will return to this island."

Adora's hands clenched into fists as her side. She kept her head low, the hood still concealing her face. She watched though. She watched Prime, who in turn was watching Catra, staring at her like a wolf stalking its prey.

"I gave you a challenge, Prime," Catra said simply. Adora didn't miss the slight twitch of her tail though. Catra was frustrated. She was fuming.

"I gave you and the rest of the suitors a chance to take the throne," she continued. Though she did her best to keep her voice level, Adora caught the faint edge of anger in her words.

"It isn't my fault if none of you could complete a *simple* challenge."

Prime's scowl deepened even more. Catra didn't entertain him or the suitors anymore. She turned and immediately left the stage, disappearing into one of the many halls of the palace. Glimmer and Bow hurried to her side, disappearing as well. Slowly, the crowd of Eternians began to disperse and soon enough it was only the suitors in the giant hall. The suitors *and* Adora.

She debated on going off into the halls herself; on following Catra and revealing herself. They could make an announcement. She could retake her throne, remove the suitors, quell whatever discourse was among her people. She could– She was in the hall now. She hadn't even realized that she had started walking.

She could hear Catra's steps echo in the hall. Hurried and *angry* somehow. She glanced down the hall, just barely catching the sight of her turning the corner and disappearing once more. Bow and Glimmer had finally matched her pace and disappeared around the corner with her. Adora could hear the rumblings of a discussion between the three of them but they were too far for her to make out the words.

She stared after them, at the corner they went around, but she didn't take another step. Uncertainty filled her again and she suddenly became *very* aware of her current appearance. A gray cloak, tattered and well worn, covered her. Her clothes under the cloak weren't any better. Her red tunic was torn in places, her grey trousers ripped in spots.

She knew her face didn't look the same anymore. Once youthful and unblemished… Now it was covered in scars. Scars from battles, some against enemies, *some* against a friend…

Without even realizing it, she had reached up, her fingers brushing one of the scars that ran across her cheek. On the opposite cheek were three scars, a claw mark from some monster she had fought sometime over the last twenty years. She had another that split her left eyebrow in two. One that ran across her nose. At some point, she had even lost the tip of her right ear…

No… She wasn't the woman who left Eternia all those years ago. She wasn't the *same* Adora Catra knew. She had blood on her hands now. Absent-mindedly, her fingers stopped brushing the scar on her face and went to the one just below her sternum. A stab wound. A *mutiny*. She sighed and her hand went back down.

There weren't any guards in the hall she noticed. Odd. There should be at least one or two. Especially if the suitors have been behaving that way for a while now. Frustration began to boil. How could her kingdom allow the suitors to be so *openly* disrespectful to her wife?

Had the suitors somehow managed to endear themselves to her people? She decided that she would ask Bow and Glimmer at some point. Some time *after* they caught up with each other.

Adora turned and walked down the other side of the hall. She decided then that she would go back out. She would go to Bow and Glimmer's. Reveal herself to them first and ask them–

"Screw this competition…"

It was Prime. His voice was harsh and there was an edge of… *something* that Adora didn't particularly care for. She made her pause by the outskirts of the archway that led back to the throne room. She leaned against the wall, staying out of sight from the suitors. *Listening*.

"We've been here for hours…" Still Prime.

"None of us can string it. We don't have the power." Another suitor. He looked a little like Prime, but his voice was different. His face too. He looked *older* than Prime.

"Screw this damn challenge, no more delays. Can't you see…" Adora peered over the archway. Prime was stalking around the suitors. All of them were watching him with interest.

"We're being played. This is how *she* holds us down. Hold us down while that *child* gets bolder. She's delaying us. Waiting for

her child to take on the responsibility of the kingdom."

A child? Adora scoffed internally at that. Finn was twenty now. They might always be a child to Adora but that was because they were *her child*.

Was Prime really disrespecting the heir to the throne in their own palace? She fought the urge to march into the throne room and demand that they apologize. She opted to wait instead. To hear just *what* they were planning.

"This is how they hold us down while the throne gets colder…"

She scowled. She wasn't dead. And even if she was dead, the throne belonged to Catra now. It would belong to Finn when they were ready.

"What do you suggest, Prime?" asked one of the suitors. Prime turned and sauntered up the suitor. It was the one who had spoken earlier. Prime put a hand on his shoulder.

"Well, Hordak, there is only *one* course of action now. Did you notice *who* left this little challenge early? Who's *alone* now?"

Adora slipped back into the throne room now. All of the suitors were watching Prime, so focused on him and his little speech, that they didn't notice her as she returned to their group. She was able to hide among them.

Dread filled her. It started to fill her when Prime first began to talk and it continued to grow. *Alone?* Who was–?

"The Queen's own precious *heir*."

Finn!

"We'll *strike* when they come back," Prime's voice was soft, smooth. "We'll wait by the entrance. Ambush them. You all will hold *them down*."

Adora's heart began to beat a bit faster. Her hand twitched to reach up and unsheathe her sword.

"Hold them down until they stop shaking. Hold them down while *I* slit their throat. Hold them down while I slowly break them, while I cut them into pieces…"

Red… Her vision began to go red. Her child. They were plotting to kill her child. She would--

Prime continued to speak, "After I'll throw them down into the sea."

Adora struggled to keep herself from reaching for her sword, unsheathing it and killing all of them now. So many suitors stood between her and Prime. There were a hundred and eight of them in total. She wasn't even sure if she could take on that many alone.

She decided that she *needed* to at least take out Prime. He was their leader. The most dangerous among them after all. Bow. Glimmer. Finn. Catra. They could handle the rest if she died. She *needed* to ensure that Prime was *gone*. She began to make her way through the crowd of suitors, her eyes only on Prime.

"When the Queen wonders where her heir is, only the ocean and I will know."

There was murmuring among the suitors now. Some excited. Some *arguing* against the whole ordeal.

(***)

"And when the deed is done, the Queen will have no one to stop us from breaking down her bedroom door."

"What about–?" Hordak was immediately cut off.

"There are a hundred of eight of us. Her *friends* will not stand a chance. *Her* guards must choose. Their lives or *hers*…" The

slickness of Prime's voice almost caused Adora to shutter. He continued, "She will have no one to stop us from taking the throne, her *love*, and *more*–"

(***)

He gasped. He turned his face down. Adora stood before him. Her hood had fallen at some point during her walk to him, or maybe she had pulled it off herself and didn't realize it. Either way, she was definitely seen now. Her golden hair. Her blue eyes, piercing and haunted now bore into his green ones. Her sword was lodged into his chest. Blood dripped down his mouth…

Chapter End Notes

Any kudos and/or comments are appreciated! I haven't had a chance to write the next chapter yet, so subscribe or bookmark to keep up to date!

Next chapter will be based on the song "Odysseus" though, so it'll be violent! After that though, we get the nice, emotional reunions with Finn in CH4 (I Can't Help but Wonder), and then the one that I am REALLY looking forward to writing, her reunion with Catra (Would You Fall in Love with Me Again). I am also writing one-shot based on that song but in Catra's POV instead of Adora's because I need both POVs, so if that's something you're interested in, I recommend subscribing to the series.

She-Ra

Chapter Summary

A stranger has come to the palace. A stranger has just taken out Prime... The strongest of all the suitors in Eternia... And the stranger looks familiar...

Chapter Notes

Alright, new chapter!! This one if filled with violence! It even starts with a beheading, so be aware if violence is not your thing! Also CW: mention of rape. It is towards the end of the chapter, when Adora is towards the end of her spree. Again, it's all stuff that's in the musical, so if you've listened to the musical, then you should be fine!

In the musical, the song is titled "Odysseus" but since this is a SPOP AU, I decided to title it She-Ra instead. I guess I could have gone with "Adoraeus" or "She-Raeus" but... that just... Nah... I'm going with She-Ra because I feel like it gets the same tone across.

I know I originally said that all the chapters after chapter one would be in Adora's POV but... when I thought about writing this particular chapter, I realized that it would be hard to write Adora's POV for these scenes. I imagine her as being in a mix of pure rage and numbness. She's basically going on a spree, killing over a hundred suitors...

Everyone wanted to see her badassery and I didn't think I could show that properly in her POV, so instead I switch it up and wrote this chapter in Hordak's POV instead. Hopefully ya'll enjoy it!

Thank you again to the amazing Lyssa for beta-reading!! I also recommend checking out their fics as well! I started reading their fic "Just Below the Surface" and it's amazing!

Chapter 9 gave me some inspiration for a chapter in another fic I'm writing, so if you've been reading "If You Wake Up Her Up, I Will Bite You" (which I will hopefully be updating next month...), be ready for some hurt/comfort now...

Just Below the Surface is rated E, so just be aware of the rating and tags before reading...

Also, thank you again, Lyssa! You are amazing and your suggestions have made this fic better!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter III: She-Ra

The sword twisted, the blade turning in Prime's chest. The stranger yanked the sword out roughly. She raised the sword up, pointing the blade at the sky. She swung, and– Prime's body fell to the ground. His head was sliced clean from his shoulders.

Hordak stood by, frozen in shock. The other suitors observed, all with wide eyes and mouths hanging open in surprise. None of them had their weapons. None of them had even considered keeping their sword or spear on them… at least *right now*, not while they were still *guests* at the Queen's palace.

Carrying weapons through the castle, especially when they were trying to court the Second Queen of Eternia… It was *disrespectful*. And until Prime had started spouting off his plans to kill the Queen's child and take the kingdom by force; they had no *enemies* in Eternia.

Until now that was…

The stranger stood there, glaring at the body of Prime. There was a scowl on her face. Her brow was knit in anger. She didn't say anything and no one dared to ask her just who she was. She didn't move. She continued to stand in front of Prime's headless corpse, glaring at it. The only movement from her was the steady

rise and fall of her chest and her hand tightening on the hilt of her sword. Her knuckles were nearly white now.

How had they missed her? How long had she been among them? Had she overheard Prime's schemes? Was that what prompted this? Hordak spared a glance at Prime's severed head. His heart rate began to pick up, he quickly looked away and shifted his gaze to Prime's body. The dread grew and then he finally turned his gaze to the stranger once again.

She was wearing a cloak. It was *tattered* and *torn*. It looked ancient. It looked like the cloak of someone who had seen so many misfortunes in their life… Was that why they had missed her? The stranger was dressed no better than a mere beggar.

Hordak glanced at her face now, trying to see if maybe he recognized her. Blonde hair long and messy fell down well past her shoulders. Her eyes, still on Prime's corpse, were *icy*. His gaze narrowed as he studied her eyes… They were *familiar*.

He was fairly certain that he'd seen them before. He just couldn't remember where… or when… His heart was *pounding* in his chest.

Those eyes… They were as blue as the ocean that surrounded this *stupid* island… *Where had he seen them before?*

Scars littered her face. A part of her ear was missing. Clearly, this *stranger* had seen her share of battles. He thought back. He was sure that he would remember someone with a face as scarred as this stranger. He knew he would remember if he ever crossed paths with a warrior as fearsome as this woman. But he couldn't recall ever seeing someone like her…

And yet… For some strange reason, he felt as though he did know her. The blonde hair, the blue eyes, though he never recalled them looking as cold as they did now… Even the *sword*… It all seemed vaguely familiar to him; as if it was from some legend or some myth he had heard long ago…

An image flashed in his head. The dread that he had been filling doubled. His heart beat even quicker now, it felt as though it was about to burst from his chest. He hoped that he was wrong.

Hordak dared to look away from the stranger. He glanced up at the stage, where the thrones were. His gaze went up until his eyes landed on the portrait above the thrones– His eyes widened. A breath he didn't know he was holding was released. His stomach dropped. The pound of his heart was deafening now. He spared the stranger another glance to confirm his suspicions and– Yes. The portrait of the long lost First Queen, regal and powerful… The stranger who stood before them now, tattered and *feral*… They were one and the same.

Before he could voice a warning to the others, the stranger spoke: "For twenty years I've suffered…" Her voice was like *ice*. Hordak fought the urge to run.

"...every punishment and pain..." She took a forward, her scuffed boot kicking Prime as she stepped past him. Her back was to Hordak and the suitors. She didn't seem to care. She took another step and Hordak realized she was heading towards the empty thrones.

"...I've faced men and monsters…" She paused for a moment. Her back was still to them but Hordak was certain that she was staring at the empty throne. After a beat of silence, she stepped up onto the stage and continued to the thrones. Her head turned upward, she was staring up at the portrait above.

"I've heard the *screams* of my comrades…" Her voice sounded *regretful*. "I've had their *deaths* haunt me…" She stopped before the throne, the throne that the Second Queen of Eternia always left empty.

The stranger reached her hand out, her fingers brushing against the aged wood of the long abandoned throne. Her gaze lingered on the portrait. Though her back was to them. Hordak couldn't read her expression, he could barely see her face. Still, her

movements on the stage, the way she stood before the empty throne, the way she had spoken just now, her tone somewhat soft and filled with sorrow… It was almost like she was *longing* for a time long past.

He heard her sigh. She stopped grazing the armrest of the throne. She turned her head and looked over her shoulder at them. The iciness in her gaze was gone… But something far *worse* flickered in her eyes... Something more *heated*. She turned her head so that she was staring at the empty throne once more.

"I come back and find my palace desecrated, sacked like the kingdoms I could not save…" The anger gave way to regret towards the end of her words.

"Worse of all…" The regret was gone. Rage now filled her voice. Bloodlust filled the air around her. It overwhelmed the room. Dread was overcoming Hordak.

Part of his mind told him to run; run before *something* happened… He elected to ignore it. Rationally, he had nothing to fear, he told himself… There were a hundred and seven of them in total. Even if Prime was gone, it was only because the stranger used stealth. If any of them had been paying attention, they would have stopped her long before she even approached Prime.

She began to speak again, her voice was shaky now, "Worse of all you I hear you dare to even *think* about touching *my* wife and hurting *my* child…"

She turned, facing them all. The portrait above of her was a sharp contrast of the person who stood before them. The Queen in the portrait was *youthful*, *carefree*, and *kind*. The *stranger* before them was *aged*, *grim*, and *hateful*.

Something was happening now. The stranger was still holding her sword, her hand tightening around the hilt. Her eyes began to *glow*.

"I." Her skin and clothes began to faintly glow as well.

"Have." The faint glow grew.

"Had." It was blinding now.

"Enough!" The golden glow *erupted*. A flash consumed the stranger. Hordak brought his hand to his face to shield his eyes. He heard the other suitors murmuring behind him. Through his fingers, he saw the glow vanish and brought his hand down.

Before them, on the stage, wasn't the stranger in tattered clothes. *No*. Before them now was a warrior. A woman who stood around eight feet tall. Her cloak was gone, replaced by a *clean* and *new* looking white shirt and pants. A red cape moved behind her. She had a gold breastplate now and a crown adorned her head.

A hundred of seven of them versus one warrior. All of them were warriors in their own right. All of them had faced battles before; numerous battles actually. They should win this fight, no problem. Hordak knew that and yet… Fear gripped him.

Hordak knew now for sure that the stranger who stood before them was the long lost *First Queen of Eternia*. Not only that, but apparently the rumors of Eternia having a hero were true. *She-Ra* was real.

If the legends were true then– There was a flash of blue. Two of the suitors cried out and immediately fell. In the middle of all of them now, stood her… *She-Ra*…

Hordak's eyes met hers. The coldness was back. He felt *frozen* under her hardened stare. He didn't have his weapon. There were a hundred and five suitors now, all without a sword or a spear. None of them even had a knife.

Hordak's gaze fell upon the shining blade in She-Ra's hand. Somehow the sword was spotless. It glowed, the shine seemingly removing the blood that *should* have stained the blade.

A hundred and five suitors versus *one* Eternian warrior. He tried to reassure himself. It should be easy. If they could get to their

weapons… He reminded himself. They were unarmed after all.

Hordak took a single step back, his eyes still focused solely on She-Ra. She was still glaring at him; *him* specifically it seemed. He dared to take another step backward, his eyes never leaving the *warrior* in front of him, as if afraid looking away would prompt an attack.

He felt something in the air.

Anger.

She-Ra's rage filled the room. It felt like a whirlwind, threatening to take anyone who dared to end up in its path.

Fear.

Dread gripped not only Hordak but the other suitors he realized. They could all feel the *shift*. They were no longer at the palace on their terms... but *hers*...

Bloodlust.

She-Ra was *hungry*. The need for *blood* consumed her…

It was suffocating. His legs felt like lead with every step he took. It didn't matter what they said now, he quickly realized. It wouldn't matter if they surrendered, or if they apologized. She-Ra was out for blood. He could feel it, in the energy that filled the room. He could see it in her eyes. The hunger. The need to hunt.

This was not just a warrior in front of him… It was a *monster*. A *beast* consumed by rage and bloodlust. A beast that could not rest until she had ended *all* of them.

An image flashed in Hordak's mind then. *She-Ra stood before him. She towered above them. Her white and gold garb was stained with blood. Her eyes, as cold as ice, were staring at him, staring into his very being. She raised her sword, somehow unmarred by the carnage and–*

He shuddered. It would *not* end like that. He would ensure that.

He took another step back, but still he didn't dare to look away from She-Ra. He took a fourth step back, She-Ra's grip on the hilt of her sword tightened. Her arm shifted. He stopped. He had to be careful. If made the wrong move then– Two of his companions broke from the group and made a run for the hall– A blue flash. They fell suddenly with a strangled cry.

She-Ra now stood beside them, her back turned to the rest of the suitors. She looked over her shoulder, somehow her icy glare was somehow even *colder* than before. She was glaring at them as if she was just *daring* them to move.

The glare didn't work though. At that moment, *all* of the suitors broke from the group, all of them scrambled away from each other, running in every direction. There was another flash of blue and gold light– Out of the corner of his eye, Hordak saw three of his companions fall. There was only one choice he could make now. A choice that only worked in the chaos that had descended upon them…

He ran.

He ended up in a group of the suitors. They sprinted out of the throne room and into one of the halls, in the distance he could hear the screams of those still unfortunate enough to still be in the throne room.

He ducked into one of the other rooms. Most of his group continued onward, but a few joined him in the room. He took a moment to breathe. There wasn't a door to shut, to help them hide better but maybe she would be too busy with the others.

"We have the advantage! Why are we hiding like mere dogs?!"

Hordak turned and scowled at one of his fellow suitors. He couldn't remember the man's name but he was being too *loud*; spouting off while they tried to hide! What madness–?

"We have the numbers! We have the might! Let's find our weapons and–"

Hordak marched up to the man and jabbed his finger into his chest.

"No!" he growled at the man, "You don't understand. This is not just any warrior! This is She-Ra! She plans for *every* fight! She has laid entire *kingdoms* to waste! We cannot rely just on strength and numbers alone–"

Two of the suitors nearby screamed and fell. She-Ra stood in the room with them, her sword somehow *glistening* and still unstained. One of the other suitors bolted. There was another blue flash. She-Ra was gone. Hordak took the moment to run out of the room himself and sprint down the hall. Screams echoed behind him; horrible, *pain-filled* screams. Cries for mercy followed him.

He sprinted down the hall, trying to find the store room where he was sure the weapons were being kept. He stopped and threw a quick glance over his shoulder. He didn't see She-Ra but she was *fast*. The legends said that she was quicker than lightning and from what he had seen, he wondered now if every rumor about the Eternian warrior was true.

He ran a check list of the myths in his head and to his horror realized that so far, every tale he was told was true. She-Ra was said to be powerful enough to lay empires to waste. Fast enough to never be caught. Smart enough to outthink even the greatest of tacticians. Without a weapon or a plan, he didn't stand a chance. None of them did.

He made his way to the kitchen. He just needed a moment to hide. He needed a moment to rest and recollect his thoughts and just *plan*. The kitchen staff was mysteriously gone. Had they somehow known that their Queen was returning? Did they decide to flee so that they wouldn't get killed by mistake?

Two of the other suitors were already in the kitchen. They were talking… *loudly*. *Morons*! Stealth would be the best way for them to survive!

"This is ridiculous! We should lay in wait! We know these halls! The odds can be tilted in our favor!"

There was a blue flash. She-Ra now stood behind them. Her face was still scowled. Her brow furrowed in anger. Disbelief now in her eyes as well as the *iciness* from before.

"You don't think I know my *own* palace?" She asked, dangerously. Her voice was low and seemed as though she almost *spat* the words at them.

The two suitors startled and gasped. They spun around in horror, their faces going pale as they laid eyes on *her*. Hordak was a few paces away from them, seemingly unnoticed by She-Ra. He eyed the doorway, and plotted his escape.

There was a cockyness to She-Ra's glare now. She seemed somewhat *amused* by the two suitor's plan.

"*I* built it," She-Ra growled in a low voice. She raised her sword and–

Hordak didn't stay, he immediately took off for the hall. Screams followed him. He ran down the hall, finally coming across a familiar room. He ducked into it; a store room.

He ran into the store room and scanned it for the weapons he and his companions had left in here so long ago, all in the name of being *good guests*…

He scowled again. The room was small. There were boxes everywhere and shelves full with a variety of items such as smaller boxes and extra supplies to give out to guests whenever they left; an Eternian custom. What he didn't see were the weapons though.

He heard someone rush in after him, he spun around. Fear gripped him. He was expecting to see She-Ra. Instead it was one of the other suitors.

"Our weapons," Hordak growled at his companion, "They're missing!"

"I think I saw the heir messing around this room yesterday!" the suitor supplied breathless.

Hordak's scowl deepened. The heir… So, the Queen's *ill-mannered* brat must have planned for this. They must have reunited with their *long-lost mother* and together they were going to kill all of them.

Interesting… If they could find the heir they could make a bargain; all of their lives in exchange for the *heir's*. Nothing else would quell the fire or bloodlust She-Ra had. It was a risky plan. But it was all they had now…

"Find the *heir*," Hordak barked out. The other suitor gave him a confused nod and then ran out of the room. He turned again and scanned the room, just to be sure that their weapons weren't in here.

Outside he heard something. *Screams*. *Cries*. *Begging*. He quickly ducked behind one of the large wooden boxes, staying out of sight.

He heard hurried footsteps as someone ran into the room. He listened to the heavy breathing of one of his companions.

"Old Queen, our leader is dead." Someone was groveling. *Pathetic*. The voice continued, "You've destroyed the serpent's head. Now the rest of us are no longer a threat…"

Hordak bit back his disgust. He didn't dare to speak up from the box and berate his companion. He didn't dare to peek up from his hiding spot and observe. If She-Ra found him, then it would be over for him.

"Old Queen, forgive us instead, so that no more blood is shed…"

Hordak leaned against the box, trying to be as small as he could be. Out of the corner of his eye, he saw a metal shield. It was shiny enough that he could see the reflection of his companion and She-Ra as she marched *dangerously* into the room, like a wolf stalking its prey…

His companion took a step towards She-Ra, moving his arms apart as if he was beckoning an old friend for a hug. Hordak realized he knew this suitor… Somewhat… The *heir* had called this one *Wrong Hordak* once as a joke, if he remembered correctly.

"Let's have open arms instead…"

Hordak watched in the reflection in the shield. She-Ra stopped at those words. The ice in her eyes disappeared, replaced with… *regret*? *Sorrow*? Whatever the new emotion was, it vanished just as quickly as it had appeared and She-Ra rushed forward, her blade swung and–

Wrong Hordak fell. Hordak didn't remember hearing a scream from him. She-Ra stood in the room, her sword glowed even brighter and then the glow faded somewhat. Still, he once again noticed that the blade wasn't stained. The slaughter from today didn't blemish its perfect shine.
He watched her reflection in the shield as she scanned the room. She took a step forward and– she disappeared in a blue flash. He was alone again.

He shrunk even more to the floor and tore his gaze from the reflection in the shield. Hordak exhaled. He took a moment. A few breaths in and then a few breaths out. He tried to calm himself. He spared another glance at the shield, using it to check that the room was clear. Except for the body of Wrong Hordak and the blood that pooled under him, it was.

Shakily, Hordak began to stand. He did so slowly, cautiously peering over the box that had shielded him, just in case She-Ra

was somehow hiding out of sight from the shield's reflection. He didn't see her. He rose to his full height. She wasn't waiting for him… Not yet at least…

It was quiet now. It was *eerie*. He needed his weapon. *All* of the suitors needed their weapons. They didn't stand much of a chance against *She-Ra*. His companions were right; they had the strength and the numbers… If this was any other fight… If this was any other opponent, they could fight with just their fists and numbers… But against the legend that was She-Ra, it was all for naught.

Weapons. *Numbers*. *A prisoner*. That is what they needed. They couldn't depend on just their own strength, on just their own large numbers (which was slowly dwindling now as She-Ra hunted them down)... No… They need something of value. *Someone* that they could exchange their lives for. Hopefully, his companion found the *heir*.

Screams echoed in the hall once more. They sounded far away. He had time. Hordak sprinted out of the storage room and down the hall, as far away from the screams as he could. The halls were stained with red; the walls, the floors, nothing was spared. More suitors were scattered around, all unmoving.

Hordak passed by a room with a closed door. He slid to a stop. *Most* of the rooms were left open. Most of the servants, he noted in the early days of his arrival in Eternia, were *lazy*… Or perhaps they were too *trusting*. On the first level of the palace at least, it was rare to come across a room that was shut.

The screams in the hall grew louder. They sounded closer now. Hordak scowled and went to the door. His hand was trembling as he grasped the doorknob. Fear gripped him as he turned it, afraid that it wouldn't open. To his surprise, the knob turned completely and he hurriedly pushed the door open. He ducked in, shutting the door behind him.

The room was dark. He didn't trust it to keep him safe. He felt around the doorframe. His hands brushed against the door as well. After a moment his hands found a latch and with trembling hands, he locked the door. He took a step back, creeping away from the door so that his shadow couldn't be seen under the gap between the door and floor.

Hordak then heard some breathing to his left. He quickly spun around. His eyes had been slowly adjusting to the darkness. In the shadows, he made out ten forms, all crowded together, huddling as if that could save them. His eyes adjusted some more and he recognized them as fellow suitors. He was safe… For now…

He scanned the room as his eyes adjusted more. Their weapons… Their swords and their spears… They were in the room.

So, this is where the little heir *hid them*…

"Damn. She's more cunning than I assumed. While we were busy plotting, she hid our weapons inside this room," one of the suitors whispered harshly.

"I find it hard to believe that the sharpest of queens left this room unlocked," Hordak growled back, keeping his voice as low as he could. The legends said that She-Ra was a master tactician. She was trained by Light Hope. Light Hope, who was rumored to be the wisest in the world; the greatest tactician of their time… Of course her pupil would take after her.

Were his comrades really so daft as to believe that the greatest warrior alive was this stupid? Were they so foolish as to not realize that maybe, *just* maybe the heir they let live would eventually try to get back at them?

Hordak wasn't stupid. He knew that if the heir had even just a fraction of the strength that their mothers had, they would have fought him and the suitors… But the heir was a coward. The heir was a weakling… The heir didn't possess the strength of She-Ra.

At some point during the day… Or maybe at some point during the week… The heir must have reunited with their long-lost *mother*…

Not even a true blood heir… Hordak scowled as he thought back to his encounters with the *stray* over the years. None of his encounters with the brat were pleasant. He knew the brat hated him. The brat hated all the suitors.

At some point the *heir* must have reunited with the infamous She-Ra and together, they must have plotted this. Yes. That was the only explanation.

"So what?" the suitor spat, "Now that we can arm ourselves, let's make the bitch rot!"

Something silver glistened in the darkness and–

"Watch out!" The second suitor yelled.

The first suitor fell with a sword poking out of his back. The blade was then yanked out unceremoniously. Hordak glanced up at the intruder; a familiar looking blonde magicat… The *Heir*.

Hordak and the second suitor grabbed the swords off the shelf nearby and immediately fell into a fighting stance.

"Drop those weapons!" Finn barked at them, their blue eyes sparkling in the darkness. Finn brought their sword up, ready to fight. "And I'll ensure you'll be spared!"

They stood tall, trying to look every bit as intimidating as their mother. The feared She-Ra. A small, cruel smile tugged at Hordak's lips. Despite their bravado, the Heir was trembling where they stood. He wasn't sure if it was from nerves or the sudden realization of the situation they were in. Whatever it was though, it was definitely a weakness.

"After seeing what the Queen would do to us," Hordak said with a scowl, "we wouldn't dare."

“I don’t want to hurt you,” Finn replied, his voice firm but *desperate*, “But trust me, I’ve come prepared!”

Hordak let out a dark chuckle. He eyed Finn’s sword unamused. He then said smugly, “Your very present has doomed the queen, young heir.”

Another suitor stepped past Hordak, closer to Finn. Finn tensed up. They took a step backwards, their tail flickering behind them nervously.

“We don’t fight fair,” said the other suitor, as they took another step toward Finn.

“Grab them,” Hordak ordered and three of the suitors descended upon Finn in a flash.

“Stop!” Finn cried. They swung their sword at the suitors. One of the suitors blocked the blow with his own weapon. He knocked the hilt of his sword into Finn’s wrist, prompting a pained cry and startling them enough that they accidentally dropped their own weapon. It fell with a clang.

Now disarmed and no longer a threat, the suitors grabbed Finn and shoved them against the wall roughly. They grunted as their face and stomach slammed against the wall.

“You made a grave mistake, your Majesty,” Hordak sneered, as he took a step closer, a cruel smile on his lips.

Finn struggled against them, trying in vain to push themselves away from the wall, away from their captors.

“*You* left this room unlocked. And now *you* will cost the First Queen her life.”

After all the bloodshed, all the lost lives of his comrades, there was no way She-Ra could live.

It occurred to Hordak then that if they used the young heir as leverage, there was still nothing to stop her from eventually hunting them down. The First Queen had spent twenty years away from her home, fighting to protect her kingdom and her family. Today just showed how fearsome she could be, how much of a killer she could be. Unless she was dead, they would never know peace again. Every sudden noise. Every flicker of light. If they didn't kill She-Ra today, then she would be haunting them for the rest of their days. There was only one way to end this.

Hordak turned his head and looked at the other suitors over his shoulders.

"Brothers, come and arm yourselves! There's a chance for us to win!" Hordak rallied the other suitors. He then returned his gaze to Finn, who continued to squirm under his grip and against the wall. Staring right at Finn, Hordak added darkly, "We'll use the heir as our bargaining chip."

Hordak and the first suitor shoved Finn to the ground, forced their arms against their back.

"Get off me! Get off me!" Finn growled. The suitors roughly grabbed them up from the floor. The first suitor held Finn's wrists tightly against each other. Finn continued to struggle against them, trying in vain to fight their way free. Hordak took the hilt of his sword and slammed it against Finn's face, making them stumble and stop fighting.

The other suitors grabbed their weapons and made for the door. Hordak scowled as he and the suitors crossed the threshold, coming back out into the hall. He did a quick scan of the hall. Bodies littered the floor throughout the hall. Streaks of blood marred the walls.

There were no more screams. No echo of heavy footsteps. It was eerie. It was silent.
There was no sign of She-Ra. There was nothing to warn them, no sound to give them any indication that she was still around…

That she was *somewhere* in the palace… For all they knew, she was *waiting*. She could be waiting in the rafters high above them, hiding the shadows.

She was fast… perhaps she had some sort of *super vision* as well? Could she be miles down the hall? Could she be watching them from elsewhere in the palace, itching at the chance to speed down the hall and slaughter them all?

It was a risky plan. But what choice did he have? They had the Queen's precious heir. Leverage… That should be enough. Demand for mercy. Demand an exchange, their lives for the life of the Queen's own child. Their lives *should* be spared now. And for good measure, they would use the distraction to kill She-Ra.

"She-Ra!" barked Hordak into the quiet halls. The name echoed. He glanced from one end of the hall to the other. Nothing. No sound came. No indication that anyone had heard him.

Out of the corner of his eye, he saw his companions shift nervously. Some of them trembled now. Some of them tightened their grip on their weapons. Hordak exhaled and shouted again, "She-Ra! Answer me!"

His jaw clenched in an angry scowl. His brows furrowed as nervousness crept in. He glanced between both ends of the hall again. Nothing but blood and bodies greeted him. After hearing the echoes of screams throughout the last… What was it? *Hours*? *Days*? The silence was *deafening*. The silence *scared* him. He had no way of knowing just where She-Ra was now.

There was no way she wasn't still here. No way she wasn't *lingering* somewhere nearby. She wouldn't leave her palace. Not when her family was still unaccounted for. He decided to press on, his voice a roar, "Show us mercy, She-Ra! And no harm will come to your *heir*."

His companions began to circle around him, shielding him a bit in case she just decided to show up and attack. Hordak stepped

closer to Finn, he brought his sword up, the tip of the blade just poking at their neck. Finn let out a hitched breath.

Pathetic.

He moved the blade a little, just grazing Finn's neck; a tiny bit of blood trickled.

"Our lives for your *heir's*," he growled, glaring at Finn now.

The heir didn't even have the courage to look at their captors. Truly pathetic. Maybe he should just end the brat now. Once they got She-Ra close enough, they *could* kill her. Maybe–

"Augh!"

One of the suitors guarding him fell.

Ten.

The other suitors were glancing around, they huddled closer together now, their bodies trembling. Hordak frantically scanned the hall. He couldn't find She-Ra though.

"Augh!"

Another suitor fell.

Nine.

"Mercy?" A new voice came. Hordak turned, immediately getting into a defensive stance. He spun around, scanning the hall but didn't see She-Ra anywhere.

"Augh!"

A third suitor fell.

Eight.

"Mercy?" The question echoed, almost tauntingly.

Hordak released a breath he didn't realize he was holding. He saw his companions tremble even more. One of them broke from the circle and sprinted down the hall– A white flash and then… The deserter fell.

Seven.

A single figure stood beside the deserter's body. Two icy blue eyes glared at Hordak and the remaining suitors.

"My mercy has since drowned."

Another flash. Another cry as a suitor fell.

Six.

"It died to bring me home."

Another suitor took off, throwing their weapon to the ground. It clattered against the stone pavement of the hall. There was a white flash. The escape ended. The suitor fell.

Five.

She-Ra's back was to them now. They could attack. They should attack… But Hordak couldn't move. The hatred in his eyes died, fear now shone in them. She-Ra looked over her shoulder, her eyes locked in with his.

"And as long as you're around, my family's fate is left unknown." She sounded numb, as if all the killing that had taken place didn't affect her. Another flash. She disappeared. The suitor holding Finn cried out and fell.

Four.

Hordak ran.

He bolted down the hall. Screams followed him. Horrid. Desperate. The screams died suddenly. It was silent again.

He continued to run. He saw a quick white flash and then– She-Ra stood before him. Her sword still wasn't stained. It glowed, as if the light was somehow cleaning it, freeing it from the red that should coat it.

Hordak turned. He would run back to where he came from. He would– Another flash and She-Ra stood before him again.

"You plotted to kill my child," she said. Anger seeped in her words.

Her sword scraping against the stone floor now, the scratching sound of it as it hit the stone pavement echoed loudly in the hall. It almost seemed as though the sound was taunting him. She stepped closer to Hordak. When he wasn't sure when his breathing came out ragged and labored. His heart pounded against his chest. There was no mercy in her eyes. She stepped closer, each step slow. Deliberate.

"You planned to rape my wife."

Hordak's grip on his sword loosened. His sword clattered to the ground. There was no point. He couldn't defeat her. She had taken out most of the other suitors now. She had probably taken out everyone at this point. She had taken out *Prime* of all people.

"All of you are going to die," she said it simply, as if she was just stating a fact.

Hordak took a step back. His whole body was shaking. He clenched his teeth, trying to still himself. It was worthless to run. Worthless to fight. All he could hope now, in his cowardice, was a few meager moments of life left. The iciness never left her eyes. She *stalked* forward. Her blade was still scraping against the stone floor.

"You've filled my heart with hate. All of you who have done me wrong."

She continued forward. She lifted her sword, so that the blade no longer scraped against the floor. Hordak felt his knees give out

and he found himself on the floor, staring up at She-Ra as she advanced. There was no escape. There was no bargaining his way out.

Her white and gold garb were stained in blood; the blood of the other suitors. It was splattered on her face, it coated her arms... Her sword remained spotless though, it glowed faintly. She continued on, her sword now raised as she neared him. She stopped just a step before him, her icy eyes were locked on him… Locked on her prey…

“THIS will be your fate!”

Darkness…

Chapter End Notes

So many questions now and most should get addressed in the next chapter! What were Bow, Glimmer, and Catra doing? Where were the guards? There were over a hundred suitors, did Adora really kill all of them alone? Subscribe, bookmark, or just look up the fic manually for the next update so you can get the answers to these questions!

Any kudos and comments are appreciated! I try to respond to every comment! It might take me a while, I usually do so when I'm about to update another fic (hopefully I'll be updating the Spider-Man Adora AU this weekend). But yeah... I read everything and I'll even go back reread comments, so please feel free to comment, even just a <3 is amazing! It lets me know that someone is reading and I'm not just writing out into the endless void that is the internet xD

Next chapter is based on the song "I Can't Help but Wonder" and will show the reunion between Adora and Finn and maybe more...? (If you've listened to the song, you should know who else will make an appearance in the chapter...).

Hopefully I'll have the next chapter done soon. I'm pretty inspired to write the next chapter of "If you Wake Her Up, I

Will Bite You", so that may get updated first and then this fic... Also, I signed up for the annual Big Bang Creative Flex! So, if you like my writing, keep an eye out for that! Also, if you like my writing, I sometimes post updates on Tumblr: author-without-a-name or Blog_Without_A_Name...

I Can't Help but Wonder

Chapter Summary

> After the slaughter of the suitors, Adora reunites with Finn and a few others...

Chapter Notes

> Chapter four time!!! This and chapter five are the two I was the most excited about writing! I'm sorry for the delay! I didn't feel confident in my ability to get the emotional aspects of this chapter written and I ended up doing some rewrites. Originally, this whole chapter was in Adora's POV but then I realized... Well, I guess it would be best to read the chapter xD
>
> Anyway! Thank you again to Lyssa for beta-reading this fic!! Your suggestions have made this fic much better than it would have been!! I appreciate you so much!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter IV: I Can't Help but Wonder

She-Ra stood over the fallen body of Hordak. Her icy glare didn't leave his body, mangled and cut down. She stood straight, her shoulders tensed. Her hand tightened around the hilt of the Sword of Protection.

The rage still hadn't left her.

The blade shined brightly, a faint buzz of magic filled the air. She glanced at the blade, still unstained by the carnage. The light grew brighter and brighter. A faint *hum* filled the air; louder and louder it the sound grew, until it nearly made her eardrums burst from the noise… Then– The glow dimmed once more. The hum faded until it vanished.

It was silent once more. She wasn't sure if preferred that to the screams that filled these halls just a few meager seconds ago. Her eyes narrowed as she studied the sword in her hand.

It never mattered how much blood the blade saw; how many limbs it cut through, or how many *lives* it extinguished… The blade was always *clean*.

Light Hope once told her that the sword was a reflection of herself. It represented her own soul, her heart, her very being… As long as the blade was unstained by the rage of war, as long as it remained pure after whatever battle it saw… It meant that Ador– *She-Ra* was as well…

It meant that she was still… *herself*… The warrior that Eternia needed… Or so, that's what Light Hope said.

Light Hope said *a lot* of things to her over the years. She gave her a lot of advice, a lot of guidance. Light Hope spent years training her to become She-Ra back when she was still young and naive; back when she was still hopeful… Willing to face the world with *open arms*…

Maybe if she had just *listened* to Light Hope back then… Maybe if she had just ended the cyclopes life, rather than spare him… Maybe her brother Adam would be here beside her again in Eternia. Maybe she wouldn't have lost the soldiers under her command. Maybe she would have returned ten years ago rather than now. Maybe–

"No…" The single word came out as a harsh whisper. A verbal reminder she had given herself nearly every day. Every day her mind would spiral like this. She would replay the events that had led up to her spending an additional ten years away from home; away from her *family*.

She closed her eyes and took a few deep breaths, trying to calm herself.

It did nothing if she dwelled on the past, she reminded herself. Doubting decisions she made back then, rethinking the choices she made in the last twenty years… It didn't do anything to help her. It couldn't take the last ten years of her journey away. It didn't bring back those who fell while under her command. All this spiral ever did was cause her more anguish.

She-Ra opened her eyes again. The rage and regret began to dull; the storm inside was fading. She felt *numb*. She continued to take some calming breaths, trying to steady herself.

She was still *She-Ra* right now. Her white and gold outfit was marred by blood; none of it was hers. Throughout the whole battle, not a single suitor had been able to touch her. They were unarmed but even at the end, when she finally encountered some arm, none of them could place a single scratch on her… on *She-Ra*…

Her back was to the hall. She knew she needed to detransform. She needed to be Adora again… The First Queen of Eternia. The wife of Catra. One of Finn's mothers…
That is who she *needed* to be. That is who she *wanted* to be.

She didn't want to be She-Ra. She hadn't for a long time now. But… She didn't quite feel like she was *Adora* anymore… She wasn't the person that Catra knew. She wasn't the person that Catra fell in love with all those years ago.

Before she became She-Ra, before she had left her little kingdom, she had just been *Adora*, a young woman who dreamed of one day making the world a better place for her friends and family.

For her people, after she had become the ruler of Eternia.

Sometimes bloodshed was unavoidable. Her gaze came to linger on the some blood splattered on the floor nearby. Sometimes war demanded sacrifice. She closed her eyes to avoid the blood. Images of the war flashed in her mind. She could feel her heart rate raise now.

Catra knew her as hopeful. The Adora that stood on the shores of Eternia, embracing Catra so fiercely… That Adora didn't have her hands stained in blood. That Adora didn't have *every* waking moment haunted by the screams and faces of her dead comrades.

That Adora once held a tiny Finn in her arms. That Adora promised to always be there for her child, to protect and love them.

That Adora had promised the same thing to Catra as well… Even when they were children, Adora had vowed to herself to always be there for Catra. To protect her from any who would dare pick on her when they were kids.

Apparently Catra had made a similar promise. She had only found out about it on their wedding day and were speaking their vows in front of their closest friends and family. More than once, Catra fulfilled that vow without her knowledge.

The Adora that Catra knew… The Adora that Catra loved… Well… She just didn't exist anymore. There was no way to bring that Adora back. That version of her died. It died to bring her home.

She didn't deserve Catra. She knew that. She also knew that there was no way Catra would love… At least not as she was now…

Would she fall in love with me again? She wondered.

She opened her eyes. Closed or open, she couldn't escape the sight of blood and death. At least with her eyes open, she was only seeing the blood of her enemies and not of the ones she once considered her friends.

She didn't want to turn around. There was so much she didn't want to face yet; so much pain and suffering she had caused. She didn't feel ready yet to see her family and her friends. She didn't want to see the carnage she caused; the lives she cut down like mere weeds just a few moments ago.

But what choice did I have? She tried to reason with herself. She needed to justify her actions. If she couldn't justify them to herself, then how could even begin to justify them to her kingdom? Her friends? Or her family?

Catra and Finn were in danger. One hundred and eight suitors. One hundred and eight guests, who had far outstayed their welcome. If it wasn't for the *rules of hospitality*, she was certain that Catra would have sent those suitors away much earlier. She probably wouldn't have even known of their presence in Eternia.

She knew her wife wasn't fond of the so-called *rules of hospitality*. Those rules that essentially governed the whole world… But Catra knew those rules were important to her. As the ruler of a kingdom, Adora had to follow them. Catra also understood that, as the Second Queen of Eternia and the rule of the kingdom while Adora was away, she had to follow those rules… Even if they were ridiculous at times.

She wasn't sure what the fallout from this would be. One hundred and eight guests had died at her hand. Eventually, there would be consequences for her choices. She just hoped that ramifications from today would wait. She would deal with them… eventually. But for now… For now, she just wanted to reunite with her family…

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Finn limped as they staggered down the familiar halls. Blood stained the walls and floors. Bodies lie scattered. Finn diverted their eyes from the sight. They looked forward; a shaky hand using the nearby wall to keep themselves upright and supported. Their breathing was harsh, rough, and *maybe*, just *maybe* a tad too quick.

Their free hand reach up, fingers carefully grazing the cut on their throat, wincing as they made contact. They could feel the blood drying on their fur. It had begun to feel slightly sticky and *gross*. The smell of iron flooded their nose. The sight of the slaughter,

the heavy scent of *death* and blood… It made Finn feel dizzy. It made them sick.

Was *this* war? Was *this* what their mom had been dealing with for the past twenty years? For years, Finn wouldn't help but wonder what it was like. They longed for the same glory that their mother had. They longed to prove themselves as a fierce and formidable warrior.

They *begged* their mama to train them. They demanded to learn the art of archery and swordsmanship, imagining the day that they could finally look at the portrait of their mother and feel some sort of *connection* to the woman who was more than likely just a memory now.

Secretly, they wished to have the same faith that their mama had. Secretly, they wanted to believe that their mother was still alive and doing her best to come back home… But wishing and believing didn't amount to much… did it?

Weeks ago, they had hatched a plan with their best friend Angel to take out the suitors. Finn wasn't an idiot, despite what they had overheard Prime and Hordak say in secret about them in the past. Finn knew what Prime's plans were. They knew that the suitors wouldn't leave until they had conquered Eternia… Even if the way they tried to conquer it was *different* from how they always imagined a conquering would occur.

Sometimes all it took to take over a kingdom was a few charismatic smiles and slick words. Play to the concerns of the people, acknowledge their worries, promise a better tomorrow *if only* they are given the reins to deliver that better tomorrow…

Nearly everyone in Eternia had lost *someone* to that cursed war. It tore the First Queen Adora away from the kingdom. Nearly everyone had a sibling, a parent, a friend… Just *someone* who had pledged their weapon to fight by the Queen's side.

No one returned from that war. No word was given about the journeys those warriors faced. All they had to go off of was years of absence and a freak storm that happened around ten years ago in the distance on the sea.

There had been another storm the previous night. A storm that was eerily similar to the one several years ago… Unlike that storm though, Finn hadn't seen any ships on the horizon. Still… There was something about the storm last. For some reason, it felt like an *omen* of sorts…

In the distance, Finn saw a figure. They were *glowing* and covered in white and gold garb of some sort. Finn stopped, their eyes narrowed as they tried to figure out who it was further down in the hall. The white immediately made them think of the suitors… They did a quick scan of the hall. Bodies of the suitors lined the hall, their blood splattered against both the walls and floor.

The white figure didn't *look* like one of the suitors… Blonde hair covered the back of their head. Blonde hair similar to Finn's own… A sword was in the stranger's hand, its blade glowed brightly, almost blinding them even when they stood several feet away.

Wait!

Finn's eyes widened. Their tail began to thrash wildly behind them.

The sword.

The hair as bright as the sun...

Finn breathed out a single word. A word that they once used to say to an old portrait hanging in the palace…

"M-Mom!"

The figure startled. She glanced over her shoulder, her eyes met Finn's… *Blue eyes… As blue as the ocean…*

Her eyes went wide as well. She quickly spun around so that she was facing them, her mouth slightly agape as if she hadn't expected to see them here.

Finn's gaze wandered to the sword in her hands. *The Sword of Protection*. The blade was glowing. It was unstained by the horrors of today Finn noticed. Growing up, they had heard the legends surrounding the sword. When Finn was a small child, they had believed every single myth about the blade. As they grew older, that belief dimmed, replaced soon by skepticism. After all, how great and magical could a single sword be? It hadn't saved their mom. It didn't bring her home…

Until now…

It didn't look dull either. And it probably should have just due to the passage of time. It was said to be over hundreds of years old…

Finn glanced back up at their mom. *She-Ra*. That was her name… At least, when she was in *this* form. She-Ra's form flickered. She glowed brightly for a moment and then– Adora stood in her place.

Relief washed over Finn. Although their mama explained that *She-Ra* and *Adora* were the same person, Finn had always found the stories of *She-Ra* just a *tad* intimidating. From the stories their mama told, they always got the sense that their mama preferred *Adora* to She-Ra and secretly, Finn decided that they agreed.

"Finn," their mom gasped. The Sword of Protection clattered to the ground.

So… *Was that my mom who rescued me back there? Who saved me from Hordak?* Finn wondered. Their tail twitched behind them. Their ears flattened against their blonde mane as the memory of Hordak and tense moments leading up to their eventual rescue flashed in their mind.

Their gaze shifted away from their mom. Finn knew that they needed to regain their composer. They chose to stare at a random

spot on the floor. Anything really, to give them a moment.

For the first time in their life, she was here! Their mom was home! For twenty years, Finn had dreamed of this moment. They used to imagine the day they would finally reunite with her. They used to rehearse in their room their first official conversation with her.

They had so many questions! Questions about themselves. Questions about Adora herself. Questions about life in general. Their mama would always answer any question they would ask. She was patient and kind but… Finn always wondered just what their mom's thoughts about things were.

Growing up, everyone had always talked about how great Adora was. Their aunt Glimmer always said that Adora was a fearsome warrior. The kingdom said she was a terrific Queen. Their uncle Bow used to talk endlessly about what a kind person she was. Of course, their mama would repeat all of those things and more...

For their whole life, Finn had always wanted to meet her. For their whole life, Adora had cast a massive shadow over them. A shadow Finn had spent their whole life chasing.

They tried to think of the questions they had always wanted to ask. Questions that had been in the back of their mind and on the tip of their tongue, every time they would look at the portraits in the palace… There was so much they wanted to know! And yet for some reason, the questions all disappeared. They couldn't recall a single one. For years they had seemed so *important*!

Now their mom was standing before them and they couldn't think. They couldn't speak. Old doubts came back. Fears that had lingered in their mind bubbled up. Their Uncle Bow's voice echoed in their mind.

...Breath…

...In and out…

A few years ago, Finn had begun to feel panic and stress at random times. They never understood why or what caused it. They kept it hidden for a bit. One time though, their Uncle Bow had found them during one of those episodes. He stayed and helped them through it. Afterwards, he gave them some advice and showed them how to use simple breathing exercises to calm their mind.

They glanced back at their mom, their mind at least a little more calm now. Their eyes met Adora's. *Blue like mine*… They realized. They knew Adora wasn't their biological parent. They knew Catra wasn't either. They knew it was only a coincidence that they shared similar colored eyes. Still though, it was a small connection between the two of them. A connection that they treasured.

They saw their mom take a step forward. Her brow was furrowed. A concerned look, one so much like Catra's flashed across her face. She looked as though she was about to reach out. She stopped. Hesitantly, her arm fell back to her side.

Does she… Does she not accept… me? Finn wondered as dread and disappointment filled them. Their tail twitched anxiously behind them. They reached across their chest and rubbed their other arm in an attempt to self soothe.

Adora hadn't seen them since they were a baby. They had lived their whole life without Adora in it and Adora had lived the last twenty years without them… For their whole lives, Finn had always had a lingering fear. A fear that they shared once with Catra. She tried to help them. She tried to quell the doubt that lived in their head… But she didn't understand… And how could she?

Maybe Adora wouldn't accept them as her child.

Their mom hurriedly glanced away. She looked so… *ashamed*. Finn's ears flickered as they heard the faintest hitch in her breathing. Their ears went back down. Yeah… She must be ashamed of them…

Maybe they should walk away now. They considered it. They almost turned then and there to take off down the hall… They stopped themselves. They took in another deep breath, trying to quell the fears in their mind.

Their whole lives they had waited for this moment. Their whole lives, their mama had told them amazing stories about Adora. Their mama had *sworn* to them that Adora loved them. That no matter what, they would always be her and Adora's kid… Remembering their mama's words, they gained their courage again.

Adora's piercing blue eyes met theirs again. She didn't look the way she did in the portraits now. She didn't look like the unmeasurable legend that they had always tried to copy. The Queen that was beloved by many. The warrior that was feared and praised by others.

No… She looked… *human*. Maybe that's all she ever had been. Maybe Finn didn't need to feel intimidated by her presence. Or by her legend. Finn took in one more deep breath…

...Inhale…

They could do this…

…Exhale…

They finally spoke. They would get everything off their chest, finally.

"All my life I've died to meet you. I thought about your name so much it hurt. For twenty years, I've dreamed of how I would greet you. And now you're here and… I…"

Their voice trailed off. Suddenly, they felt very small. The courage they had gotten for just that brief moment disappeared. They wouldn't stop talking though. Not yet at least…

"And I… I can't find the words…"

Finally their voice faded. Their gaze flickered then to their feet. Shame filled them.

Why couldn't they find the words? Why was this so hard? Their mom had gone to war. She spent two decades away from home. She probably fought terrible monsters. And yet here they were, terrified to talk to her.

Scared of saying the wrong thing. Scared of looking like a coward. Of never measuring up to *her* legend, *her* story.

Why was this so hard?

Their tail thrashed behind them. They stopped rubbing their arm, their other arm came back down. Their hands balled up into fists. They couldn't let fear control them anymore. This was simply talking. They could do this! They had to!

They glanced back up at their mom. Her brow was still furrowed but she gave them a small, encouraging smile. It briefly filled them with confidence. They continued, although their voice still sounded too small for their liking.

"All my life, I've died to know you. There are so many days and nights I wish I could show you. For my whole life, I couldn't outgrow you. Your legends… And now… Now you're here!"

With each word, their confidence grew. Their voice became more sure, more firm. But as always, doubt crept back in. The small smile on Finn's face faded. The old fear lingered. They had to know. They just had to…

"All my life I've wondered, what your world must be. If we're like each other. If I have your strength in me. All this time I've wondered if you would embrace me as your own. For twenty years, I've wondered and I've felt so… so alone…"

Tears that Finn hadn't realized were there fell. They tried to blink them away, but more fell. They tore their gaze away from Adora.

Great…

Their first time meeting their mom and they were crying. They kept their gaze on the wall, trying in vain to blink away the tears that remained. When that didn't work, they looked down at their feet again.

"Oh, my Finn…"

Their ears flickered in their mom's direction. They just now realized that she had been quiet this whole time. Her voice was… *familiar*. They hadn't heard it since they were an infant and yet… They recognized it.

They heard it sometimes when they dreamed, they realized. It was comforting. It was calm. Immediately, Finn felt at ease… But the tears didn't stop. If anything, they fell even harder now.

"Look how much you've grown," Adora continued, her voice still soft and gentle and *kind*…

Their mama always used to talk about how Adora had the kindest voice. Finn never quite understood what that meant… Until now…

"Oh, my Finn, you are the sweetest joy I've known. Twenty years ago, I held you in my arms…" There was a longing in her voice now. Longing for a time long past. For time neither of them would ever get back.

"How time has flown…" Her voice faded much like Finn's had earlier. Finn dared to glance back up at her, letting the tears fall freely. They could see tears forming in their mom's eyes as well now.

"I can only wonder what your world has been like. The things you've had to suffer. And the strength you hold within…"

Strength?

What strength did they hold? Finn knew they weren't strong. They knew they would never measure up to either of their parents. They were weak. They couldn't take down the suitors. They tried but they got captured almost immediately. They suddenly felt the cut on their throat again as the memory of the storage room popped back up in their head. They fought the urge to touch the cut.

"All I've ever wanted was to reunite with my family," their mom continued. And Finn's eyes grew wide. *My family… So does that mean…?*

Their mom continued, "For twenty years, we've both wondered but today… Today you're not alone. My child–"

My child… My family…

Finn rushed forward.

"I'm finally– Oof!" Finn barreled into their mom, embracing her tightly for the first time in their life. They felt Adora's arms wrapped around them. Their ears twitched as she said in a relieved whisper, "I'm finally home."

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Adora embraced Finn tightly. She felt their tears through her tattered cloth. She desperately tried to blink back her own tears… But when she realized she couldn't, she let them flow instead.

"I'm home," she whispered to Finn. She heard a faint sob from them.

"I'm home," she repeated, tightening her embrace. She closed her eyes for a moment, once again trying to stop her tears.

For Twenty years they had both waited. She spent Finn's whole childhood worried about them. She wondered about the kind of person they would grow up to be in her absence. Twenty years now… Now she was finally *home*…

She opened her eyes and they grew wide. A familiar face greeted her. A face she hadn't expected to see… Bow stood a few paces away, alongside was a young man. They were watching her and Finn. Bow's mouth hung open in disbelief. He was holding his bow in one hand, an arrow in another– *Thud!* He dropped them. She could see the tears begin to fill his eyes as well.

The young man, who looked so much like Bow, glanced between the archer and her. His brow was knit in confusion. He had a bow nocked and ready to fire in his hands. A quiver, almost empty, was strapped to his back.

She knew that Bow wanted to say something. She could see the internal battle in his mind. She was reminded then that it wasn't just her family who had missed her during her absence. She hadn't seen Bow or Glimmer either since she left… She knew that she needed to see them. She needed to talk to them as well… But Finn needed her right now… And Bow knew that. He understood that.

She mouthed a single word to him: *Wait*.

He nodded. He didn't say a word. Instead he simply offered her a small smile.

Adora held Finn for a few moments more. Their sobs slowly began to quiet. She didn't want to end the embrace. She wanted to keep holding Finn. She had twenty years of her absence to make up for… But she had more she had to do today as well.

She needed to let her kingdom know she had returned. She needed to see her friends again. She needed to see *Catra* again… Twenty years and she had *hurt* so many. Warriors *died* under her command. Her own brother lost his life because *she* wasn't strong enough to protect him.

As much it pained her, she slowly broke the embrace. Finn glanced up at her, their blue eyes shining with tears. With one hand, she cupped their face, the side that wasn't bruised. With

her thumb, wiped away the tears that hadn't fallen. Her hand slipped off their cheek.

"Please, tell your…"

She suddenly couldn't remember what name Catra decided to go by. What name she had wanted Finn to call her. She frowned at herself.

"Hey, Finn, go tell your mama that your mom's home," Bow said gently.

At some point, he had closed the distance between himself and Adora and Finn. He stood beside both of them, giving them both his kind smile; a familiar smile that she hadn't seen in twenty years and until this moment, didn't realize just how much she missed seeing it.

Finn glanced between the two of them. They quickly wiped away whatever tears remained with their sleeve.

"Y-yeah…" they said, their voice still rough.

Bow then glanced back at the young man. He hadn't joined Bow when he came forward. He kept staring between the three of them; Adora, Bow, and Finn…

Every time Adora's eyes landed on the newcomer, it was like looking at an old photo. The man looked nearly *exactly* like Bow, save for a few differences… For some reason, their eyes and nose reminded her of Glimmer…

"Angel, would you please go with them?" Bow asked, giving the young man a smile.

Angel? Wait! Then that's–

"Of course, Dad!"

His voice! He sounded so much like Bow when the four of them were young. For a moment, Adora could have sworn it was Bow who spoke. Angel un-nocked his bow and threw it and the arrow back into the quiver. Finn began to walk past her.

Catra was about to find out that she was home. *Twenty years* and her and Catra would finally see each other again properly! As soon as she saw Catra, she would bring her wife into a tight embrace! From the very moment she had departed from Catra's arms on the shores of Eternia, she had dreamed of this day–

The excitement quickly gave way to dread. Old fears bubbled up. And the lingering doubt that had begun to plague her ten or so years ago, came back in full force… She had to do a lot of bad things to return. She sacrificed her *own* warriors, her own citizens, to come back home… She wasn't the same Adora Catra knew. The same Adora Catra loved… What if… What if she was *too* different now? What if Catra didn't want her around anymore?

No…

Catra had made it clear this morning that she was still waiting. Adora knew that she just needed a few moments to prepare herself. A few minutes to quell the fears inside her mind.

Before Finn and Angel could get too far, she called out. They both stopped. Finn's ear flickered in a way that was so reminiscent of Catra that brought a small smile out of Adora.

"Tell her I'll be there in a moment… Please?"

"Of course!" Finn replied, their voice sounding less rough now.

Finn then took off down the hall, almost at a full sprint. Angel ran after them. Finn limped a bit as they ran, which almost resparked Adora's rage. Anger almost overtook her again. For a brief moment, she could feel the too familiar flow of She-Ra's magic. Her skin glowed for a moment– Out of the corner of her eye, she saw the blood that stained the wall and floor. The glow vanished.

The cause of Finn's pain, the threat to her family's safety… they were already dead. She didn't have anyone to fight.

With Finn gone, Adora turned her focus to Bow. His small smile grew then, almost taking up his whole face. Her own smile grew as well and– "Oof!!" Bow embraced her in a tight hug, lifting her up a couple of inches off the ground.

"I can't believe you're back!" he exclaimed excitedly.

After a moment, he lowered her. His grip loosened and Adora could finally return the hug.

"I can't believe it either," she admitted, her voice quiet.

She really couldn't believe it. Since the day she left Eternia, all she had thought about was the day she would return home. The day she would see her family and friends again.

Although there was a part of her that often wondered if Bow's presence during the war would have made their journey home easier, their trials less… Another part of her was glad that he didn't join her.

She lost everyone under her command. Soldiers who were once childhood friends. Warriors who swore to fight by her side until their dying breath. She was already dreading having to face the families and friends of the fallen. She wasn't sure if she could bear to look at Glimmer if she had to report that Bow had been lost to the war or sea.

The two finally ended their embrace. Bow clasped her by her shoulder, studying her for a moment, his gaze softening as he seemed to finally notice the new scars that decorated her face. She could see the questions forming in his eyes, the concern that lit up in his gaze.

She didn't feel ready to answer questions yet. She knew that eventually she needed to. Bow deserved answers. And so did Glimmer, Catra, and Finn… All of Eternia really. Before she could

tell Bow that she would answer any questions he had but at a later time, he spoke, "You know… We saw a storm ten years ago. We all *assumed*… Well…"

He looked ashamed for some reason. He averted his eyes from her for a moment, as if he was trying to recollect himself. She heard him take a couple of deep breaths. His eyes met hers again.

"Adora, for so long now… All of Eternia believed you were dead."

Dead…
She shouldn't have been surprised but a part of her was. She was gone for so long. She supposed that it was only fair for her kingdom to have given up on her. Still though… It hurt knowing that her people had basically written her off. A casualty of war.

"I… I don't think Catra ever did though," Bow added, his tone sounding almost wistful.

"She… She didn't?" Adora dared to ask, her voice was low and was close to breaking. She could feel tears gathering. She hurriedly blinked them away. If Bow noticed them, he said nothing. Actually, he must have noticed them, she realized, as he quickly looked away, giving her a moment to gather herself as they continued to speak.

"No…" he confirmed firmly. He cast her a quick glance and seeing that she had managed to recover somewhat, returned his gaze to her.

"Glimmer and I… We… We both kind of assumed that…" His words trailed off.

She could hear the faint hints of worry in his voice. She could see the shame on his face. She held a hand up to stop him. To stop him from worrying about her reaction. To stop him from feeling the shame that was threatening to consume him.

"It's okay, Bow. I… I didn't think I would make home either. There were plenty of moments where I thought I was going to die.

Where I wished I had died. I just…" She sighed, trying to recollect herself once more.

So much had happened. She wasn't the same Adora who left all those years ago. She never would be either. War changed her. The journey home changed her.

She knew in her heart that she hadn't truly returned home… Not all of her at least. So maybe her people were right. A part of her had died. It had died to bring her home. Her thoughts turned back to Catra. A question that had been lingering in the back of her mind returned…

Would she fall in love with me again?

"Adora?" Bow's concerned voice brought her out of her thoughts. His brow was furrowed in worry. Before she could say anything to quell his anxiety though, a familiar chime filled the air…

"Adora!"

Glimmer barreled into her much like Finn had. She was holding her tightly, her body shaking violently as she embraced Adora. Adora snaked her arms out of Glimmer's grasp and returned the hug earnestly.

Except for a few rough sobs from both women, it was quiet in the hall. A few moments went by and then Glimmer finally released her, her pink eyes meeting Adora's blue ones.

"I can't believe– When Finn said that–" She embraced Adora again, letting the words die on her lips. After a few more moments, she broke the embrace once more. Like Bow earlier, Glimmer took a moment to study her. Her expression softened as she seemed to realize just how *different* she looked now. Adora couldn't help but notice how Glimmer's gaze seemed to linger on the scars that now littered her body.

"Listen… You should…" She stopped, as if she was carefully considering her words. She sighed, seemingly deciding to just get

whatever she was going to say over with, "Before you see Catra, you should really get cleaned up. Bow and I will take care of–" She waved vaguely at the hall. Adora tilted her head in confusion.

"Augh! You know!" Glimmer said vaguely, still gesturing at the hallway. Adora quickly scanned the hall and then realized… The *slaughter*… It was at that moment, she also noticed that Glimmer's outfit was stained with blood. Her eyes widened in alarm. She glanced at Bow and saw that his clothes were also covered in blood. But it didn't seem like either of them were wounded…

"Listen, I'll go grab you some new clothes… Well, not *new* but *cleaner* clothes… I'll tell Catra to get cleaned up as well," Glimmer said quickly.

Catra… Cleaned up… Wait! Then did that mean that Catra had been fighting some of the suitors as well? Before she could ask, Glimmer poofed away…

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Adora slowly stepped out onto the courtyard. It used to be her and Catra's favorite place. They would bring Finn out here in the mornings, usually taking turns on who would hold them. They would enjoy the cool air of spring; breathe in the salty air. They could see some of Eternia's beaches from here. They used to watch the waves in the distance.

She was cleaned up now. Her old clothes and the cloak she had worn for so long were in a pile on the floor of the one of the guest bathrooms. Part of her wanted to burn them. She thought about doing it while she waited for Catra. She decided not to though.

Glimmer had found her some clothes. They weren't new, in fact, they were actually an old favorite of hers. Grey trousers that were now too big and loose… Glimmer had at least also brought her a belt. Her familiar red tunic hung loosely off of her now. The last

time she wore it, it felt perfectly against her frame… Now though… It just reminded her of how things had changed during her absence. How much she had changed…

Her and Catra spent years building this courtyard, with Bow, Glimmer, and her brother Adam often helping whenever they had a spare moment. The section closest to the palace had several trees planted around it, with the hope that eventually those trees would grow big enough to provide them with some shade in the future. There were a few concrete benches offering them a place to sit and just enjoy the day.

The trees had grown in her absence, casting most of the grey stone pavement in shadows, and providing the courtyard that much needed relief from the sun… Just as she had hoped they would.

Beside one of the benches was an apple tree, already bearing fruit. A smile, soft and sad, touched her lips as her gaze came to rest on it… This one was the one her brother had planted for them back when it was just a sapling. It had been an anniversary present for her and Catra. Adam used to talk about how he couldn't wait to see the little sapling grow up. He wasn't even here to see it now.

She continued through the courtyard. A little further out, it opened up. She used to practice with her sword out here. Sometimes Bow would join her and they would spar. She stopped in the middle of the pavement, staring out now at the ocean so far away. It was evening now. The sun was just beginning to hit the horizon. A few clouds gathered in the distance, enclosed in a pink hue… In the distance she could see the waves.

She stood for a moment and watched them. It was more relaxing to watch them from here. Her feet on solid ground, her body not rocking with the ship as it sailed over the waves. Seagulls cried as they flew overhead.

She turned, her back now to the beach and glanced up at her palace. Her gaze came to rest on a single open window; *their* bedroom window. In the mornings, she would usually glance up and catch Catra standing there, watching her as she trained. It always brought a smile to her face.

Catra wasn't standing there right now though.

The window was open. She could make out the sight of the curtains as they swayed, pushed by the cool evening breeze that now swept through the island. She wasn't sure if Finn was still up there. If they were still explaining to Catra that she was home once more. Or if maybe Glimmer had been able to help convince Catra that she was back.

Glimmer had said something about Catra needing to clean herself up… Maybe that's what was taking so long. It must have been roughly an hour since she sent Finn upstairs to let Catra know she was home.

She hated waiting. She spent so long waiting to see Catra. Waiting to step foot on her island again. Waiting to see the familiar faces of her friends. Waiting to see her child. Another few hours wouldn't kill her. She still hated it though…

Suddenly, she felt a familiar presence. One that she hadn't felt in about ten years. Adora sighed. She wasn't sure if she was ready to face *her*… Not yet anyway. But she supposed that she didn't have much choice in the matter. She never really did when it came to *her*…

"Show yourself," Adora commanded, her voice quiet and sharp. She knew it would be better to get this reunion out of the way quickly.

"I know you're watching me… Show yourself," she repeated, her voice slightly more firm now.

There was a sound. One that was a little similar to the sound of Glimmer's teleporting… But she knew it wasn't Glimmer who now

stood behind her. She felt a *familiar* set of eyes on her. The new presence felt heavy and stern. She didn't need to turn around to know who it was but she did anyway.

"You were never one for hellos," Adora commented dryly as she came face to face with her old mentor.

"Adora…" A voice she hadn't heard in about ten years said.

"Light Hope," Adora said simply.

Shame and anger rose in her. For so long, she had done everything Light Hope had demanded of her. She spent years training to be the perfect warrior. The warrior that her mentor said the world needed. She did all she was asked.

…And yet… When she finally pushed back, when she *dared* to question her, and make her own choice… She was abandoned. Her mentor left her.

…Maybe if she had retained Light Hope's guidance… Maybe then she would have at least returned home with most of her companions…

"Adora… I'm sorry," Light Hope said suddenly.

Adora startled visibly. She stared at the A.I questioningly. Maybe she was dreaming. Maybe she hadn't returned home at all. Maybe she was still stranded on that island. There was no way her mentor had just apologized. She scratched her palm with her finger nail, not enough to draw blood, but enough to ensure to herself that she was awake.

"You know…" Light Hope continued, her wistful voice bringing Adora out of her thoughts, "I can't help but wonder what this world could be. If we had held each other with a bit more empathy. I can't help but feel like I've led you astray–"

Astray? You left me! You– Light Hope continued on, seemingly unaware of the spiral she was putting Adora through.

“What if there’s a world where we don’t have to live this way?” Light Hope then looked to her. Her blue holographic eyes felt as though they were staring straight through her. Through her very soul.

For years, Adora had imagined just what she would say to Light Hope if she ever had the chance to reunite with her. Light Hope had put her through so much.

Grief.

Anger.

If it wasn’t for Light Hope choosing her, she probably never would have left Eternia. Maybe no one would have. Maybe the island would have six hundred more people on it.

Maybe– Adora sighed. She had spent so long hating Light Hope. So long wishing that Light Hope had just understood why she decided to spare that cyclops ten years ago.

Empathy wasn’t a weakness. Adora tried to remind herself. Empathy was a strength. Anyone could kill their enemy. To forgive your enemy though… To give them another chance… Was that not strength?

For so long, she had wished that her mentor had just understood that. Understood her. And now she did… apparently. It was just ten years too late. Instead of voicing all of that though, Adora simply said, “If that world exists, it’s far away from here.”

At one time she had dreamed of such a world. A world that didn’t need *She-Ra*. A world where her family could live safely. She wanted Finn to grow up in such a world. It was part of the reason she left Eternia to begin with. To help create such a world.

Instead, she allowed danger to come to her home. She allowed people like the suitors to harm her child.

No… A world such as that… It wasn't in Eternia. And she knew it wasn't anywhere near Eternia for that matter. Adora continued, "It's one I'll have to miss. For it's far beyond my years."

She had already lived half her life. She didn't have the energy to create such a world anymore. And with the amount of blood that stained her hands… It wasn't her world to create anymore. Maybe Finn could. Maybe one day Finn would. They were still young. They were still hopeful and their hands were covered in blood like hers were.

Even if Finn couldn't, she knew *someone* who could. *Someone* who wasn't affected by time like she was. Maybe that task should fall to *them* rather than her or Finn or any who came after them.

"You might live forever, so you can make it be," Adora suggested. She kept her tone soft, hopeful. Maybe with some encouragement, Light Hope would follow through on such a task. Maybe… It wasn't Adora's responsibility anymore though and maybe it never should have been…

"But I've got one endeavor, there's… *someone* I have to see…"

Catra flashed in Adora's mind. During her youth, she often felt the strong tug of destiny. She wanted to be of service to her kingdom. To the whole world… But that was during her youth. Now… Now all she wanted was to see Catra.

She had already seen her friends. She had finally reunited with Finn and she would spend the rest of her life being there for them. Now, she *needed* to see Catra.

A soft, knowing smile graced Light Hope's lips.

"Very well," she said and in a flash, she disappeared, leaving Adora alone in the courtyard once more.

Maybe the years had softened Light Hope. Maybe the last two decades had changed them all…

Adora cast one last glance at the bedroom window stories above her. Catra still wasn’t there. At least, not where Adora could see her… She heard hurried footsteps in the courtyard and glanced in their direction. Finn ran to her, stopping just a few feet away.

“Mom, she’s waiting for you.”

Chapter End Notes

I would also like to thank Rinnii, the author of one of my favorite on-going SPOP fics "The Nyanny"! I am using the name they used for Bow and Glimmer's kid in this fic as well!

Also another thank you to Lyssa! I was struggling with deciding between having the reunion set in Adora's POV or Finn's POV and she was able to help me with that decision!

Kudos and comments are greatly appreciated!!! Thank you to everyone who has left comments and/or kudos in the past! I try to respond to every comment! Sometimes it might take me a week though! But I do read them (there's been a few that I have read multiple times, especially when I'm needing a boost!)

Thank you for reading this fic!! One more chapter is left! I started writing it but due to some personal stuff going on, I not sure when it will be completed but hopefully soon! I want to have this fic done before April!

Would You Fall in Love with Me Again?

Chapter Summary

> After twenty years apart... After sailing thousands of miles of perilous seas... Facing unimaginable horrors, dangerous monsters, and a witch who had sought power... Adora has returned home. She's reunited with Finn. She's seen her closest friends. She slaughtered the threat to her family and kingdom...
>
> Catra waits for her. And she longs to see Catra. But the sins of her past weight heavy on her and thus a single question haunts her mind as she goes to reunite with the love of her life...

Chapter Notes

> Well! This is it! Kind of... Be sure to read the ending notes for an important announcement! I don't want to spoil anything so I'm not posting it here XD
>
> Anyway, I hope you all enjoy this final chapter! I was (and a little still am) stressed about it. The Epic musical is important to me! It is one of my favorite musicals and if you haven't listened to it, I really suggest you do! Jorge Rivera-Herrans did an excellent job of adapting the story of The Odyssey! His musical is why I read through the story FINALLY awhile back!
>
> I want to thank my beta-reader for this fic Lyssa once again! Seriously, your suggestions really made this fic better! I don't think I can express my gratitude and appreciation enough!! Your kind words motivated me and built up my confidence so much while writing this!! Also, ya'll can thank her for the announcement in ending notes XD

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter V: Would You Fall in Love with Me Again?

A deep breath…

A fist half raised, ready to give a light tap.

Twenty years…

She had faced war. Fought every kind of monster imaginable. Sailed thousands of miles of sea. Witnessed the deaths of some of her closest comrades. *Caused* the deaths of those who remained by her side even through the worst of their challenges. The shame that always lingered in the back of her mind pushed its way forward…

She had done *all* of that, just for the mere *hope* of seeing Catra once more. And now all that stood between their reunion was a door. A simple door, once crafted by her own hands.

She shouldn't have to knock. It was her own bedroom. Her own palace. She should just open the door here and now and enter the bedroom. Embrace Catra. Apologize for being gone for so long… But she couldn't.

Adora sighed. She lowered her closed fist. She bowed her head, which immediately made contact with the door, creating the very light tap she was too scared to create to begin with. She cringed and promptly moved half a step away from the door, hoping that Catra hadn't heard it. She waited, straining her ears for *any* sound from Catra on the other side…

Nothing…

She sighed again. She wasn't sure if she was relieved or disappointed. She berated herself. Why was this so hard? So much time away… So much time spent fighting for her life… She had spent days and nights longing to be in the same space as Catra.

Catra…

She was waiting…

Waiting for me… That tiny bit of hope returned. It filled her.

For the last few years doubt had stirred in her mind. It had threatened to consume her more than once. For the most part, she had pushed it aside, choosing instead to focus on her eventual return. On her eventual reunion with her friends and family…
She was a monster now. She knew that. The slaughter against the suitors proved it. And what kind of person would just *sacrifice* their own soldiers? She had grown up with most of the warriors under her command. One of them was her *own brother* and she wasn't strong enough to stop his death…

The doubt grew again. It was at the edge of her mind, wrestling with the hope that *just* began to spark once more…

Finn had accepted her. She reminded herself. Her own child had been so *happy* to see her…

Glimmer and Bow too. They both welcomed her back with open arms and reassuring embraces.

So why was it so hard for her to see Catra now? Why did the very thought of seeing her wife, who had loved her for years… who was the person she had longed-for during her journey… who was the last face she pictured before sleep claimed her… who was the one she *dreamed* endlessly of night after night… Why did the thought of seeing Catra now fill her with dread?

Adora closed her eyes. A breath, rough and ragged, holding back a sob, escaped. Her fists clenched and unclenched. Her chest felt oddly tight. Her heart felt as though it was about to burst, its very beat echoing in her ears.

Thump… Thump…

It was loud. Too loud. Everything was just *too loud*! Even her own breathing was too loud for her own ears.

She closed her mouth, forcing her breathing to go through her nose instead. She needed to calm herself! She knew that! She couldn't… No… She *wouldn't* let Catra see her like *this*!

A mess.

A disgrace.

A *failure*.

She had promised Catra she would return. She almost broke that promise. She said that war wouldn't change her. She *definitely* broke that promise. Maybe because of that, she broke the promise that she would return.

She wasn't the same Adora who left. She knew that without a doubt… The cost of war, seeing the fall of her own people, making the decisions she *had* to make… More than once, she had drifted off to sleep, replaying old decisions, wondering if she really had made the right choice…

She didn't feel *worthy* to walk into her own bedroom. She didn't feel *worthy* to look upon her wife… To stand in her presence… to *embrace* her. Or to even have her own name spoken by the voice she had spent the last twenty years longing for.

She reminded herself that Catra knew she was here. Catra knew she was *home*… *Somewhere* in the palace. She wasn't sure how Glimmer had managed to convince her wife to not barge down to the courtyard and see her.

Even if she didn't feel worthy to stand in Catra's presence, she couldn't just leave. She had to let Catra make that decision for herself. She had robbed Catra of the last twenty years. She couldn't rob her of this choice as well.

Adora opened her eyes, lit up with newfound determination. The courage that had helped her face the two decades was rekindled. She raised her closed her fist and raised it once more. She gave three quick but firm knocks on the door… And then she waited…

There wasn't a sound. She didn't hear the groan of their old mattress as someone got up, nor the faint scrap of the chair as it was pushed against the floor. She didn't hear the hurried footsteps of *someone* behind the door…

It was silent…

It was *unnerving*…

It threatened to extinguish the fragile hope that had been building…

For years she waited… She fought. She stood at the threshold of death, defying it each and every time…

Years…

and yet now… Now, a few meager seconds felt far longer than the last two decades.

Adora decided that she couldn't wait a moment longer. Her courage was quickly dwindling, ebbing away to the old tendrils of fear and doubt… She wanted to bolt right then. Leave everything and *everyone* behind. She didn't deserve to see them. She shouldn't have come back. She gripped the last bit of her courage and forced herself to stay…

For Catra… She reminded herself… After all, she owed Catra this.

She was about to knock on the door once more, her closed fist was raised, hoovering just a few inches away from the wood. It was about to make contact with the door– suddenly there was a sound on the other side. She strained herself to hear. A latch was undone. Adora lowered her hand. Her mind raced. Catra's face, older now and somber as the day she left Eternia, flashed in her mind. She usually paced when her thoughts were too active. She couldn't do that now though…

The door creaked as it opened. Half a face with a single gold eye, weary and skeptical, greeted her. The door covered the other half

of her face. Quickly, a smile graced Adora's face. The single golden eye widened– but just for a moment. The weariness returned and it caused Adora's smile to falter until it faded completely.

Was Catra not excited to see her? Maybe after twenty years she had moved on. Maybe she didn't have a place in her life anymore… Old fears returned. It gripped her tightly.

"Catra," Adora breathed out, somehow her voice holding both excitement and dread.

Catra's ear flickered. Something flashed in the one visible eye. Too quick for Adora to know what it was though, as it disappeared just quickly as it had appeared… Adora wasn't sure what emotion it was and that bothered her.

"Come in," said a voice, low and *tired*… Catra sounded so *tired*, it made Adora's heart clench. She took a step back, opening the door fully and stood beside it, beckoning Adora in.

Adora gave her a quick nod and stepped inside. As much as she wanted to look at Catra, she couldn't help but give her room a quick glance over. She wondered just how much had changed in her absence. How much she had missed out on… To her surprise the room looked almost *unchanged*. Untouched by time. Even the white writing desk, which Catra had threatened to move out of the bedroom numerous times, because she would "overwork" herself, was still there… She thought for sure that Catra would deliver on that threat sometime during the last twenty years.

Adora continued to scan the room, searching for even a small change. Just something to indicate to her that life had gone on without her. Her gaze eventually landed upon a portrait above the fireplace. Her eyes widened. It looked so much like the one downstairs. She knew it wasn't the original.

The original was downstairs and was much too massive to be moved… Whoever created this one had done a good job though.

The paint and color looked similar, almost identical but she knew it was a copy. It was their family portrait. She and Catra stood together, Finn nestled in her arms, probably asleep. It was supposed to be the first of many family portraits…

Her gaze lingered on that painting. She wondered how much time had passed before that copy was made. How long until Catra had decided that the palace needed a second version of it. She also wondered who created it. If Catra had commissioned it, or if maybe one of their friends had done it just as a gift… Not that it mattered. It was in their bedroom, so clearly it had some value to Catra.

Adora heard the faint sound of the door close behind her. Out of the corner of her eye, she saw Catra. She sauntered past her. She felt her wife's gaze on her, watching and studying her with intensity. She tried to stand straighter. As Catra moved past, their eyes met. There was a mix of emotion in her wife's mismatched eyes. Some that Adora had expected to see…

Pain…

Loss…

And some that Adora hadn't expected…

Disbelief…

Concern…

She thought she would see anger in them… but she didn't… And she wasn't sure if she should feel relieved about that or concerned…

She noticed that Catra's tail wasn't flickering as it always did. It was still as she walked by. Straight and rigid behind her back. She wasn't sure what to make of that, what it meant… A new fear came over her then. She realized to her horror that she couldn't *read* her wife.

She used to know everything about Catra. Every flick of her ears. Every twitch over her tail. Even without words, she could read her wife flawlessly. She could even before they were married, before they were even officially *dating*... Thinking back now, she wasn't sure if her anf Catra even had dated. Since the moment she gained the courage to say *hi* to Catra, it felt as though they belonged together.

Twenty years apart and she and Catra had both undergone changes. She spent the last few years wondering just how much Finn had grown up during her absence. Of the trials and challenges her child had faced without her. She hadn't really considered that Catra would change as well.

Her wife's face looked *older* now. There were faint signs of age. Wrinkles and worry lines near her eyes, which… didn't seem to shine as bright as they once did. Adora's brow furrowed for a month as she took in her wife's appearance. The fierceness *was* still there. It was present, but only *just*. A tiredness that Adora was too familiar with herself had crept into the light of Catra's gold and blue eyes.

Her fur had greyed as well. Grey and white had started to speckle in her maroon hair. She was a little *thinner* than Adora remembered, as if she had spent the last few years skipping meals. Not enough to be *dangerous*... Not yet… But still it was enough to be noticeable. She supposed that the only reason Catra looked as healthy as she did was for Finn. Even if *she* didn't return, Catra still had Finn to take care of.

Her heart clenched again. She put family through so much while away. She did it to protect them. Maybe she caused *more* suffering instead…

Catra was still watching her. Her gaze was measured, her eyes searched her up and down, as if looking for any changes. Any signs she might be *different*, Adora realized. Catra's gaze zeroed in on Adora's face, but instead of meeting Adora's eyes, it landed upon the scars.

Self-consciously, Adora's hand moved up. Her fingers gently grazed three scars across one of her cheeks. A souvenir from a monster she fought some time ago. Catra was quiet. Her brow furrowed and she looked away. There was something in Catra's eyes then. Adora wasn't confident in what emotion it was.

Anger?

Pain?

She could imagine Catra being angry. Frustrated, more likely, that she had been reckless enough to get hurt in the first place.

She could also picture Catra feeling a sense of pain at seeing her current state. No doubt, her wife had expected her to return to Eternia as she had left it. Unfortunately, that wasn't the case.

She was afraid that Catra was disappointed. Dismayed, perhaps, that she couldn't be who she was before. Not only had she returned twenty years too late, twenty years older, she had also returned home battered and a shell of her former self.

Adora hurriedly diverted her gaze away. She couldn't bear to look at Catra and whatever expression was now on her wife's face. She was reminded again of all the mistakes she had made.

Catra had waited for so long. She didn't even change their bedroom, except for the addition of the new portrait. She even held onto her old clothes. The very tunic Adora now wore was one she used to wear all the time here in Eternia. She no longer felt like the same person Catra fell in love with all those years ago…

Before her shame could build up anymore though, Catra's voice interrupted her.

"Is it you?"

Adora glanced up, immediately their eyes met. Catra looked so… *uncertain*, Adora realized. Her voice had been low, almost *broken*,

as if she was holding back a sob. She felt her heart clench again. How could she do this?

"Is it really you standing there, or am I dreaming once more?" Catra asked. Her voice was still low, almost quiet. Almost unheard by Adora. She sounded apprehensive, as if she didn't believe Adora was truly standing before her.

Before she could even respond, Catra took a step forward. The pained expression on her face made Adora shut her mouth. In just a few steps, her wife closed the distance between them. Catra reached out as she neared her. Her fingers brushed gently against the scars on her cheek. Adora closed her eyes. She felt both of Catra's hands cup her face then. A thumb carefully prodded the mark that split her eyebrow in two.

"You look…" Catra's voice, soft and gentle, broke through the recesses of her mind. It saved her before she could even begin to spiral once more. Her next word didn't prevent the storm that was brewing in her thoughts though…

"...*different*…"

That stung. Adora exhaled through her nose. Hesitantly, she opened her eyes, hoping that the hurt didn't show. She was met by the familiar yellow and blue eyes. Eyes she had spent the last few years longing to see. To her surprise, Catra's expression was blank now. She didn't see any traces of anger and concern in her wife's gaze. Catra was studying her. Appraising her, it seemed.

"Your eyes look tired," her wife noted. The softness of her voice hadn't faded. Though she spoke a *little* louder now. Probably to ensure that Adora could actually hear her.

Catra removed her hands from Adora's face and took a couple of steps back. Immediately, Adora missed her touch. Her piercing gaze moved onto the rest of her body. She was quiet for a moment. She was still examining her. Her gaze seemed to soften… And then, "Your frame is slighter…"

Once more Adora became aware of how loose her tunic felt. She used to fill it out. The sleeves were once snug against her arms… Now it didn't feel as though the muscles she had earned through years of hard work and training even touched them. They didn't feel like her clothes anymore.

"Your smile…" Catra's words faltered. The softness in her expression gave way to pain then. Pain for *her*, Adora realized. And she didn't deserve it. Catra continued, concern shook in her voice, "...torn…"

Adora tried to give her a small smile. She wanted to give Catra *some* sign that she was still here. That was still *Adora*… Even if she wasn't the same Adora, she was still the same woman who had fallen in love with Catra all those years ago…

Maybe if she knew that. Maybe… Maybe Catra would fall in love with her again? The new her?

"Is it really you, Adora?"

Twenty years… Every day, for twenty years she had longed to hear that voice. To hear it say her name. She dreamed of that voice. Sometimes falling asleep to the memory of it in her ears. The question repeated itself in her mind then:

Is it really *you*?

She wanted to say yes. She *longed* to say yes. She wanted nothing more but to forget the last twenty years. To forget everything that had happened. To forget every death, disaster, loss… Everything that had befallen her after leaving. To forget the years they spent apart.

She wanted to say yes and return to being the *Adora* Catra knew. The one Catra fell in love with… But she wasn't. It didn't matter how much she wanted to be that version of herself. It didn't even matter how much Catra wanted her to be that version of her… She wasn't the same person anymore. And she had to let Catra know.

She took a deep breath, preparing herself to answer. No matter how much it hurt, she was determined to tell Catra the truth. A selfish part of her hoped that Catra would understand.

…*Inhale*…

…*Exhale*…

She braced herself for whatever was to come. For whatever Catra's reaction would be.

"I am not the one you fell in love with," Adora finally admitted. Her voice was quiet, almost timid.

Catra frowned. Adora's stomach dropped. She felt her heart constrict. She quickly averted her gaze away from her wife, choosing now to focus on the floor instead. War and monsters… She could face all of that, but she couldn't face the disappointment Catra would undoubtedly feel towards her. Catra deserved the truth though. She wouldn't lie to her. She would never lie to her wife.

"I'm…" her words began to falter. Her courage ebbed away. She screwed her eyes shut. She closed her mouth. A few deep breaths. She needed to gather whatever courage reminded. She opened her eyes again. She couldn't face Catra. She wouldn't look at Catra as she dashed her hopes of her wife returning. But she would at least let her know.

She heard a quick intake of breath. Her guilt grew. She had to press on though.

"I am not the one you once adored. I am not your kind and gentle wife. And I am not the love you knew before…"

She took another deep breath. Tears began to prick in her eyes now. She tried to blink them away, instead they fell. Dripping down her cheek and onto the floor below. She needed to calm herself. She needed to be here for Catra. She could deal with her own emotions later. Right now, she needed to be ready for Catra,

to be… *whatever* her wife needed. Stranger or her wife… She would do either for Catra. If Catra wanted to stay, she would. If Catra wanted to leave… She would.

Inhale…

She blocked out her emotions. She sealed deep inside her mind. Her eyes shut even more. The tears finally stopped.

…*Exhale*…

Maybe the hard part was over now. She told Catra she wasn't the same person. Maybe Catra wouldn't ask for the details. Maybe she would let her past go and fade into obscurity.

A question rose from the deep recesses of her mind then. A question that had haunted her for years now. After every poor decision, every mistake, *that* question had begun to form.

It was probably stupid to ask… But then again, she was always foolish when it came to Catra. And if she didn't ask, then she would never know… She wasn't sure if she could live the rest of her life with *this* particular question unanswered. Or at least unasked. If Catra didn't or *couldn't* answer it, then that was her right. She would respect whatever her wife decided.

Gathering the last of courage, she glanced up at her wife. She looked… *broken*. She wasn't sure if that look was aimed at her, or if it was how Catra felt about herself right now. Still, she dared to ask the question that had been on her mind for years now.

Their eyes met. With the last of her courage, Adora asked, "Would you fall in love with me again?" She was surprised at how much her voice wavered as she asked.

Something flickered across Catra's face then. Adora wasn't sure what emotion it was. She thought for a brief moment that Catra had opened her mouth as if to respond. But then it closed just as quickly.

Old fears gripped her again. And so, Adora continued. She rambled on, her words never ceasing until she got it all out, "If you knew all I've done? The things I did that I cannot change? Would you love all the same? I know that you've been waiting."

Tears began to force themselves in her eyes. She quickly looked away again, she couldn't… No… She *wouldn't* let Catra see her like this.

"I'm… I'm so sorry, Catra," she almost whispered the cry. She blinked the tears away again and after a few moments, feeling as though they were finally gone, she glanced up at her wife once more.

To her surprise, she saw tears glistening in Catra's eyes as well. She felt the too familiar clench of her heart again. She didn't want to cause Catra any more pain.

"I know you've been waiting for so long," she continued, her voice was rough and raw. A sob was threatening to break in the back of her throat. She wouldn't let it. She had to be strong.

Both of them had been waiting. But only one of them knew *why*. Only one of them had made questionable choice after questionable choice. *Only one* had lost themselves during the past twenty years.

It was Adora's fault. She knew it. She accepted it. She just hoped that Catra would forgive her. Forgive her and maybe accept her for who she was now.

She watched as Catra blinked away the tears that had formed in her eyes. Her expression quickly flickered back to blank… *Unreadable*…

Adora thought she saw her wife take a deep breath. Catra was probably mad. She was probably frustrated with everything Adora had put her through. It was her fault the suitors had come. Her fault that she had to raise Finn alone. If only she could have stayed.

She looked away again. She mentally tried to prepare herself for whatever Catra's reply would be. No matter what, she would do whatever Catra asked.

"What kind of things did you do?" Catra probed, her voice soft despite the weighedness of the question.

Adora dared to glance back up at her wife. Catra's expression was still neutral. That filled her with dread.

For a brief, selfish moment, she considered lying. Maybe Catra would accept a lie. Maybe she could just say, she was different because she was older now. She wasn't the same Adora because she wasn't the twenty-something that left all those years ago… She couldn't.

No matter what, she would tell Catra the truth. The whole truth. Of every mistake she made. Of how she caused the deaths of innocent and guilty alike. She opened her mouth to answer. She would lay out every mistake she made during her time away…

But when she began to answer, she found that the memories were too strong. They were still too *fresh*… And so, instead of listing everything she had done, she opted for a simple answer. Maybe one day she would tell Catra the whole story. Maybe even talking about it would help her… But that day wasn't *today*.

"I left a trail of red on every island. I traded my friends like objects I could use."

Her friends, long deceased, flashed before her. All of them were lost due to *her* own poor decisions. Lost so that *she* could return home, so that *she* could see her family once more.

They gave her their swords and bows. They promised their undying loyalty… And she replayed them by allowing them to die. She even fought some of her own soldiers, all because they had a disagreement on whether the journey home was even feasible anymore. They wanted to live. She just wanted to see her family. She was even willing to die herself if it meant she could get just

one more day with them. Even if it was just a glimpse. She had to see Catra and Finn.

She continued, her voice growing quieter with every word. She thought she saw Catra's ears strain forward, as if to hear her better as her words trailed off.

"I hurt more lives than I can count on my hands…"

But there was a *reason*! Adora reminded herself, *A reason for the bloodshed*.

Another memory flashed before her. A scene much like the palace today. Bodies were scattered around her. A *witch* with a red mask was doubled over before her. Trembling… Adora saw herself as *She-Ra*. She watched herself as she raised the *Sword of Protection* up– The memory vanished. But she still knew how it ended.

She-Ra was feared across the world now. Her name was whispered in hushed and horrified voice by the other kingdoms… As long as she was alive, she was confident that no one would dare to rise up against Eternia.

Selfishly, she hoped that Catra would understand and maybe even look past her mistakes. She hoped that Catra wouldn't view her as the monster she had to become. It was the only way she could return home after all.

Hopefully…

Adora knew she had to explain. She had to give her reason. She held Catra's gaze. Her eyes lit up in determination and she pleaded with her wife to understand.

"But all of that was to bring me back to you," Adora said earnestly.

It was true. Everything she did, every sacrifice she made… All of it was just for the mere *chance* of seeing her wife and child again. Finn had accepted her. Maybe Catra would as well.

Her wife's face was still unreadable. Her tail still didn't move, not even a tiny flicker. But Adora also noticed that her ears didn't pin back… Adora hoped that was a good sign…

"Please, Catra," she began to speak again, surprised herself. She didn't expect to ask again, to beg her wife. Her voice was desperate but she continued on, not letting her embarrassment hinder her from speaking, "Please, tell me, would you fall in love with me again? Even if I can't undo the things I did."

Her heart was beating quickly in her chest. Too quickly. It was deafening to her. Her words poured out, even quicker than before. Her mind raced.

"And I know I'm not the Adora you once knew."

She only hoped that Catra would understand. That she would forgive her. Without stopping, she continued, the desperation in her voice growing, her panic raising. Her guilt… "I know that you've been waiting…"

Adora's voice finally trailed off. Her shame finally won and she tore her eyes off of Catra. She tried to blink away the new tears that were forming as her guilt grew. She knew she needed to calm herself. She took a few deep breaths. Feeling ready again, even if just for a moment, she glanced up at Catra once more.

She almost wished she hadn't. Catra was staring at her. Appraising her once it seemed. Her brow was furrowed and a small frown tugged at her lips. *Disappointment*… Of course, that's what Catra would think of her. She was a failure. She wasn't the same *Adora* anymore. She had failed Catra.

She heard her wife sigh. It was heavy and weary. It added to her ever growing guilt. Catra's tail twitched then. It swayed a bit here and there and then it went still again. Adora wasn't sure what that meant.

She wondered then if she should just leave now. Maybe she could wait outside. She could give Catra a few moments to decide what

she wanted. She knew she wasn't worthy to even stand in the bedroom she shared with Catra. But she didn't want to leave the palace yet, not unless Catra asked her to, of course. She would do whatever Catra asked.

For not the first time, she thought back to the day she met Light Hope. The day she became She-Ra… And she cursed that day. Legacy. A kingdom. None of it mattered. It never did.

For so long, all she wanted was Catra. She longed to be by her side. Along the way, while trying to impress Catra, she had earned those other titles; *First Queen of Eternia*, *She-Ra*… Titles earned her the respect of everyone. Titles that seemed to make Catra proud as well… but now… She would give them all up if only to feel as though she could stand beside her Catra once more.

Catra's voice broke through her spiraling thoughts. It was soft and gentle. She didn't deserve to hear the compassion in that voice… Adora hadn't even realized that she had stopped looking at wife again. She felt as though she was suddenly snapped out of a looming darkness. She had been staring at her boots for… she wasn't sure how long now.

"If that's true…" Catra's voice trailed off then.

Adora glanced up once more. Their eyes met. There was… *something* in Catra's eyes. Adora wasn't sure what to call the emotion that lingered in Catra's gaze. She cursed herself for not knowing her wife anymore.

Catra continued, her voice tender and kind…

"Could you do me a favor?" Catra asked.

A favor? She wasn't sure what Catra would ask of her but anything her wife asked, she would do. Anything.

"Of course," Adora replied quickly.

She was surprised by how low and rough her voice sounded. A new emotion flickered across Catra's face. It lasted only for a moment, but Catra looked almost *pained* at hearing Adora's voice then. It vanished as quickly as it had appeared though. The softness returned to Catra's face.

"Just a moment of labor," Catra continued, the tenderness never leaving her voice, "That would bring me some peace."

"Anything," Adora answered earnestly. Out of habit, she stood straighter. Whatever labor Catra needed her to do, she would. She had built this palace herself; all for Catra.

For a moment, Adora almost swore that she saw a soft, amused smile touch Catra's lips. It vanished as quickly as it appeared though, with a quickness that made Adora wonder if she had even saw it at all. Maybe she was just imagining things.

Catra crossed her arms over her chest and nodded at something to the side of the room. Adora followed her nod, wondering just what Catra was asking and why she didn't just say it. Her eyes came to rest on the large bed. *Their* bed. She was confused now. Maybe she was looking at the wrong thing.

"You see that wedding bed?" Catra asked, her voice breaking through the fog in Adora's mind as she racked her brain, trying to come up with a reason for why Catra had nodded at the bed.

What? Immediately, she felt her face go red. Okay, so maybe Catra wasn't mad then… Adora glanced back at her, her mind racing now.

Just what–? Before she could ask, Catra continued, "Could you carry it over?"

C-carry it over? Her thoughts sputtered, her shock morphed back into confusion once more. She glanced at the bed again. Catra continued, apparently not noticing bewilderment at the request.

"Lift it high on your shoulders and take it far away from here," she requested. The softness and tenderness were gone now. She sounded more *neutral* all of a sudden, almost bored. As if she was requesting something as ordinary as *throw this away*…

Take it far away from here… The request echoed in Adora's mind. Her fingers twitched on instinct. Old pains returned.

"How could you say this?" Adora asked, her voice suddenly sounding far away even to her own ears.

Scars, much older than the time she had been away, suddenly itched. Her fingers and hands were adorned with them; tiny nicks and scars, some barely noticeable. Most of them she got during the *months* she spent, painstakingly, carefully, *lovingly* handcrafting *that* bed.

It was a gift. It was supposed to be a declaration of her love. She had nicked herself several times by accident while carving it out. Catra had scolded her every single night. Every new scar meant a new lecture… But truthfully, she adored every little nick and scar she had obtained from that project. It was a reminder to herself of how much she was willing to do. Of how much Catra meant to her. She had hoped Catra had thought of the bed in a similar way. A sign of how deep her love for her ran… *But apparently not…* That thought hurt. It pained her. Something else bubbled up in Adora.

Sadness.

Anger.

She wasn't sure which she felt more strongly about. She couldn't believe that Catra would be so willing to get rid of such a gift. One that should outlast them. Not only that, but the task itself was *impossible*…

And Catra should know that… Catra knew what the bed was made of. She had even called Adora an idiot for suggesting this project… She wanted to ask Catra if she remembered.

Maybe she was wrong. Maybe Catra had forgotten her after all this time… She wanted to ask Catra if even understood what she had asked of her. Instead, her anger took over. It pulsed through her, threatening to consume her.

In a near growl, she asked, "How could you say this?"

She wasn't even looking at Catra. Her eyes were still set on the bed; appraising every detail she had caringly carved so long ago. That bed was older than Finn.

"I built that wedding bed with my blood and sweat," Adora continued, her voice shaking with anger and disbelief. Every little nick on her fingers continued to twitch.

"I carved it into the olive tree where we first met," Adora's voice steadily grew louder with every word. It trembled from emotions she tried to keep at bay.

"A symbol of our love everlasting…" She barely heard her own voice now. She felt far away suddenly.

The memory flashed in her head. She had watched Catra from afar for so long. Wanting to go up and just *talk* to her but her nerves always won out. Until one day… She *finally* approached the magicat while she sat under the tree.

They were much younger then, children still. She wasn't sure why, she had always felt some pull to Catra. As if she had known her in another life. Maybe they had. Maybe in some other life, they didn't spend years separated from each other. Years longing for the other…

Sitting under that tree… It became *their* spot. They would sit under it for hours. Sometimes they would talk, excitedly telling the other about their day. Other times they would sit in silence, enjoying each other's company, watching the sea and the waves as they hit Eternia's shores…

She built her palace around the tree. All so she could carve into its very trunk to make their bed without uprooting it. Although Catra had called her an idiot for even suggesting that, she hadn't missed the way Catra's eyes lit up when she saw the finished project.

The memory faded. Adora was in their room once more. Her eyes were still on the bed. The task Catra had asked of her still weighed heavily on her mind. Twenty years… Had Catra truly forgotten during that time?

"Do you realize what you have asked me?" Adora demanded, her gaze still on the bed. She blinked back tears that she hadn't realized she had until now.

Angrily, she glanced at Catra. She was standing beside the desk. Her expression unreadable again. If her wife felt *anything* about this request, then she wasn't showing it. That fed into her frustration even more. Adora's ire grew. Her anger with everything in this situation consumed her. So many were the subject of her wrath now:

Light Hope for choosing and training her to be She-Ra.

She-Ra for being the reason she was away.

The *witch* Shadow Weaver who had started that *stupid* war to begin with.

The last *twenty years*… Every day, every hour, every *minute* of the last twenty years felt cursed.

Catra for making such a request… How could she? How could she make this request? She was practically asking Adora to remove a sign of her love for her.

Herself… Ultimately, she was to blame. She listened to Light Hope. She became She-Ra. She left to fight Shadow Weaver. She was *gone* for the last twenty years. Could she really blame Catra for wanting her to remove a sign of her love?

She tried to push her rage aside. It wouldn't change anything. She didn't want Catra to see it either… She couldn't push it aside.

"The only way to move it, is to cut it from its roots," her anger, raw and consuming, seeped into her words. She was surprised by the harshness of her own voice now…

She expected Catra to match her ire then. To Adora's surprise though, she didn't… Instead, a smile, soft and small, tugged at her wife's lips then. The blank expression shifted, and a familiar look adorned her face.

Catra *smirked* at her. Her eyes held a new light. It was familiar. She was staring at Adora *fondly* she then realized. Without even saying the word, Adora could hear it. A simple word. One that only Catra could make sound like a term of endearment… *Idiot*…

"Only one person knew that," Catra said suddenly. Her voice was affectionate. She uncrossed her arms, a soft chuckle escaped her. The smirk didn't leave.

"*Only* one blonde idiot knows the story behind that bed," Catra repeated, the fondness in her voice growing, "So I guess… I guess that makes her… *you*…"

Her anger diminished. Her eyes widened a bit at the remark. This whole time, she didn't feel like the same person who had left all those years ago. But in just a few minutes, Catra had proved to her that wasn't the case. In her core, perhaps, she still was the same Adora…

She uttered a single word in a shocked, almost broken sob, "Catra…"

She heard a heavy exhale from her wife. Exasperated perhaps… Catra took a step forward. Adora then noticed that her wife's eyes were glistening with unshed once more.

"Adora," Catra said the name firmly, like a gentle reprimand, "I will fall in love with you. Over and over again."

Adora continued to stand there, as if her feet were stuck to the spot. Catra continued. She took another step, and then another.

"I don't care how long it's been. I don't care how, where, or when…"

The distance between them steadily closed. Tears fell freely from Adora's eyes, trailing down her cheeks. She saw that Catra's did the same as she continued forward.

"No matter how long it's been, you're mine."

You're mine… Those two words echoed in Adora's mind. She breathed out a relieved, choked sob. Catra's face grew softer as she approached.

"Don't tell me you're not the same person…" It was a gentle reprimand; her tone soft.

Adora couldn't look at her anymore. The shame filled her again. Catra had so much faith in her. Hope. She didn't deserve it. She didn't feel as though she should be standing before her wife. She heard Catra's steps falter then.

"Adora, look at me," came the gentle request. She glanced up at her wife once more. There was a fierceness in Catra's expression now, coupled with the softness from before.

"Don't tell me you're not the same person," Catra repeated, her voice still gentle though firm as well. It was a tone her wife used over the years with her. It always seemed to come out whenever she believed Adora was pushing herself too hard.

"You're my Adora. You'll *always* be *my* Adora."

The distance was closed now. Catra reached out, a single hand cupped Adora's face. Adora stared deeply into the blue and yellow eyes, filled with tears much like her own…

"And I've been waiting…" Catra's voice was a whisper now, barely, audible.

"Catra…" Adora cried, tears streaming down her face; she closed her eyes to stop them, but they wouldn't cease.

Twenty years, she had fought for the mere *chance* to return to her wife's side. She did things she regretted. She lost people, all because she wanted to see Catra once more. It was overwhelming somewhat. For so long Catra was just a memory in her mind. A fond memory that kept her going. Kept her *alive*.

Hearing her voice, having it grace her eardrums. Seeing her once again, outside of her dreams and thoughts. Feeling the warmth of her hand on her cheek and leaning into the familiar and loving touch… A touch she had spent the last twenty years *longing* for…

Catra carefully threaded through Adora's hair, one hand still cupping Adora's cheek. Adora leaned into the touch, savoring it. For the first time since she left Eternia, she felt… *safe*...

"Waiting for *you*…" Catra murmured, her voice still a whisper. Adora opened her eyes and found herself staring deep into her mismatched eyes. Catra's gaze was tender and yet *somehow* intense as well. Adora had spent so long missing those mismatched eyes.

Twenty years *they* waited…

Twenty years they *longed* for each other. They spent too much time apart. Too much time worrying about the other. Too much time wondering if they would even see each other again… If the other was *alive*.

With one hand still caressing Adora's cheek and the other still threaded within her now graying hair, Catra inched forward. Adora could *feel* her wife's breath. Catra leaned in, slowly. Adora closed her eyes.

She spent days and nights dreaming of this. She had waited for so long. She *waited* for just a *moment* more…

Their lips met…

It was gentle… Hesitant at first, as if they didn't truly believe the other was really there, that this moment was no longer a dream but rather reality. *Their* reality…

The moment lasted longer. The hesitation faded away. Catra was still here! *Here*! She hadn't vanished as she often did in Adora's dreams, sudden and like wisps of smoke, leaving Adora grasping at empty pockets of air.

No.

Catra was still here. Her fingers carefully threaded into Adora's hair. Catra's warm lips pressed against hers. A hand still gently cupping her cheek, grounding her in reality…

The kiss gradually grew in intensity. She didn't want to part from it. She promised herself she wouldn't.

Twenty years and it all vanished in the blink of an eye. The weight of her journey before left her. The past didn't exist anymore. Instead her mind was on the here and now. On Catra and their future together. She had a lot of lost time to make up for.

Twenty years, she had longed for this moment. And it was worth it…

After a bit, Catra pulled back. Somewhat disappointingly, Adora opened her eyes once more, wishing that the kiss had continued. Her disappointment vanished as soon as her eyes met Catra's though. Catra's gaze was filled with a love and understanding that Adora had missed for so long. She felt her wife's hand shift to the back of her head. Adora finally reached out, hand brushed through Catra's hair. It was longer now and much grayer than before, she noticed.

So much time had passed. Too much time in fact. She didn't want to spend that long apart again. She hoped that they would never have to. She wanted to remain by Catra's side forever. For the rest of her life, whether that meant another two decades or just another *day*.

She would never be separated from her wife again, she decided then. Whether She-Ra or a Queen of Eternia… The world would have to figure it out itself. She wanted to do one thing with the rest of her life and that thing would start today.

Adora closed her eyes and breathed a sigh of relief. For the first time in years, she was *happy*. She was free. She felt Catra's eyes on her, and opened her own. She was immediately greeted by pair of gold and blue eyes, staring at her warmly.

Fond...

Familiar...

Full of love and maybe just a tint of amusement...

"How long has it been?" Catra asked with a light chuckle.

Adora couldn't stop the grin that formed on her face.

"Twenty years, I guess…" She mused, with a soft laugh. She couldn't help but notice how Catra seem to light up at the sound. A slight smile now adorned her own face as well. She felt… *relieved*... Relieved to finally be home and to finally be holding *her* Catra again.

An intense light overtook Adora's eyes then and she said, "I'll never leave you again." She said it firmly. As seriously as when she had spoken her vows to Catra on their wedding day.

Catra's expression softened even more then. Her smile grew.

"Good," she said, her voice nearly a whisper, "I don't want you to, Dummy."

They both leaned forward. Their foreheads met. Adora relished feeling this close to Catra again.

They gazed deep into each other's eyes. A soft purr rumbled now, filling in the silence that had fallen between them. It was *loud*. It was *calming*. It was a sound Adora had long missed.

Then they spoke. Their voices intertwined as if in a sweet melody. Three words were spoken… Three words that they *both* had longed to say and they had *both* longed to hear…

"I love you."

Chapter End Notes

One last thanks to Lyssa for beta-reading this! I saved this thanks for the end because... spoilers! XD

She helped me with so much while writing this fic! And with the kiss scene in particular! Also, she is responsible for this scene:

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***

Alright, important announcement! So if ya'll remember, I made this a series. I wanted to keep this particular fic at just five chapters, with each chapter being focused on one of the songs from the album. I tried to focus on just one POV for

each chapter (that changed in CH4 because I alternated between Finn and Adora). I knew for CH5 though that I wanted to have both Adora and Catra's POV but to avoid the confusion of switching between the two, I decided to write one version in Adora's POV and another version in Catra's.

I will be writing and posting a companion fic with Catra's version of the CH5, so her "unreadable" expressions, we'll actually know what's she's thinking. But in addition to that... I will also write a chapter that goes over what Catra was doing after she left the suitors in CH1 and what she was doing during She-Ra's slaughter of the suitors. I know a few people have said that they wanted to see Catra join the slaughter, and Lyssa expressed interest in knowing what Catra was doing during that time.

CH3 (the slaughter chapter) was set solely in Hordak's POV, so he missed most of the slaughter. He knew what was going on but his view is skewed. Even Adora doesn't know what exactly happened during that time because she was filled with rage and focused solely on taking out the suitors...

So, be on the lookout on the companion fic! It'll be in the series, so I suggest subscribe or bookmark the series. I am hoping to have it written and posted sometime in April. I know March is still early and it still could happen in March but I am also bound and determined to finally finish "If You Wake Her Up, I Will Bite You" later this month. I hate having incomplete fics in my bio so I'm trying to count down on them.

Anyway, I hope you all enjoyed this fic! Kudos and comments are always appreciated! To everyone that has left kudos and commented, THANK YOU!! Ya'll motivate me with comments!

End Notes

Any kudos or comments are greatly appreciated!! Gonna be honest, comments make my day!

I do not have a timeline on when chapters will be posted, so if you like this fic and are interested in the rest of it, I suggest you subscribe or bookmark. Anyway, quick summary:

CH1: The Challenge

CH2: Hold Them Down

CH3: She-Ra

CH4: I Can't Help but Wonder

CH5: Would You Fall in Love with Me Again

I am also writing and plan to post a one-shot of CH5 but in Catra's POV because I need both POVs for this particular chapter and I can't be the only one xD

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!